

# Are galaxies in compact groups special?

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## ABSTRACT

**Context.** Compact groups combine high projected densities with low velocity dispersions, but many are embedded in or projected onto larger structures. Their evolutionary significance depends on whether their galaxies remain distinct from regular-group analogues, not only from field galaxies.

**Aims.** We test whether CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies remain special after removing split systems and comparing them with ordinary four-member groups, luminous regular-group cores, and projected compact cores around brightest group galaxies. We ask which observable carries any residual signal: morphology, star-formation state, colour, AGN-like activity, group-scale structure, phase-space position, or local projected tidal density, and galaxy size at fixed stellar mass.

**Methods.** We use the CG<sub>4</sub> sample inherited from the Tricottet et al. construction, leaving 62 compact groups after the split-system cut, and compare it with RG<sub>4</sub>, Control<sub>4B</sub>, and Control<sub>4C</sub>. We combine Galaxy Zoo vote-fraction morphologies, SDSS stellar masses and specific star-formation rates, optical colours, emission-line diagnostics, seeing-corrected structural sizes from the Simard et al. catalogue with SDSS Petrosian radii as a cross-check, adjusted binomial models, and one-to-one matched controls.

**Results.** CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies, especially satellites, are more often elliptical/smooth and less often spiral/features than their regular-group analogues. This satellite-weighted morphology signal survives adjustment for stellar mass, redshift, rank, and available group-scale quantities, and is also present in matched comparisons. The star-formation signal is weaker: CG<sub>4</sub> satellites have a lower raw star-forming fraction, especially relative to RG<sub>4</sub>, but this contrast is not comparably robust after adjustment and matching. Among galaxies that remain star-forming, we find no robust compact-group offset from the star-forming main sequence. Colours, AGN-like fractions, magnitude gaps, and the limited H $\alpha$  diagnostics do not support a simple instantaneous-quenching, fossil-group, or AGN-driven explanation. A projected pairwise tidal index diagnostic reframes part of the morphology signal as a local projected-density effect; it is not direct causal proof of the time-dependent tidal field. At fixed stellar mass, the adjusted models show no significant CG<sub>4</sub> offset in seeing-corrected half-light radius, although the one-to-one matched pairs formally prefer smaller CG<sub>4</sub> sizes, a control-dependent contrast that we treat with caution.

**Conclusions.** Compact groups host a more morphologically evolved population, consistent with accumulated transformation in dense group cores and/or preprocessing. The evidence favours a cumulative structural or morphological signal over a uniquely isolated compact-group quenching mode at the present epoch.

**Key words.** galaxies: groups: general – galaxies: evolution – galaxies: interactions – galaxies: star formation – galaxies: elliptical and lenticular, cD – methods: statistical

## 1. Introduction

Compact groups of galaxies are useful laboratories for environmental evolution because they combine high projected galaxy densities with relatively low velocity dispersions (Hickson 1982; Hickson et al. 1992). In such configurations, repeated tidal encounters, dynamical friction, mergers, gas stripping or consumption, and disk heating can plausibly accelerate the transformation of galaxies compared with more diffuse environments (Barnes 1985, 1989; Verdes-Montenegro et al. 2001). This expectation is closely connected to the broader morphology-density and star-formation-environment relation, in which galaxy structure and star-formation activity vary systematically with local density (Dressler 1980). Multi-wavelength studies of compact-group galaxies likewise report altered infrared,

UV, star-formation, and population properties relative to looser environments (Johnson et al. 2007; Walker et al. 2010; Tzanavaris et al. 2010; Bitsakis et al. 2010, 2011; Coenda et al. 2012; Plauchu-Frayn et al. 2012).

The interpretation of compact groups is nevertheless ambiguous. Projected selection can include chance alignments, and many Hickson-like systems need not be isolated bound entities. Simulations and redshift-space analyses have long shown that apparent compact groups may be transient alignments, dense substructures, or cores embedded in looser groups and richer haloes (Mamon 1986; Díaz-Giménez & Mamon 2010; Díaz-Giménez et al. 2012; Zheng & Shen 2021). The relevant observational question is therefore not only whether compact-group galaxies differ from field galaxies, but whether they remain different

from galaxies occupying regular-group analogues selected with comparable luminosity, redshift, and membership constraints.

Recent structural work strengthens this motivation. Using S-PLUS imaging and single-Sérsic measurements, Montagnath et al. (2023, 2025, 2026a,b) identified transition galaxies and trends in the  $R_e$ –Sérsic-index plane that point to structural transformation in compact groups, with stronger signatures in non-isolated compact groups and host structures. These studies suggest that compact groups can mark sites of cumulative structural processing. They do not, however, by themselves answer whether compact-group galaxies remain distinct after comparison with regular-group cores selected from the same parent catalogues.

Our previous work (Tricottet et al. 2025) addressed the question of whether compact groups are special as dynamical systems. We found that, once the direct consequences of the compact-group selection are accounted for, compact groups of four galaxies have group-scale properties broadly similar to those of regular groups of four galaxies and to the cores of richer regular groups. This motivates the complementary question addressed here: even if compact groups are not strongly distinct as systems, are their member galaxies individually different? We therefore use the same compact-group and regular-group framework to compare galaxies rather than groups, controlling for stellar mass, redshift, galaxy rank, and available group-scale properties. We then identify which observable, if any, carries the residual compact-group signal: star-formation class, Galaxy Zoo morphology, optical colour, AGN-like activity, fossil-like magnitude gaps, projected phase-space position, or local projected tidal density.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the samples, the sSFR and morphology classifications, and the statistical hierarchy. Sections 3 and 4 present baseline population differences and group-scale diagnostics. Section 5 tests which signals survive adjusted and matched comparisons and examines secondary diagnostics. Section 6 discusses the physical interpretation of the morphology signal, and Section 7 summarizes the conclusions.

## 2. Data and classifications

### 2.1. Samples

We use the compact-group and control samples constructed in our previous study (Tricottet et al. 2025). We briefly recall their construction here. Galaxy properties are taken from the SDSS DR12 catalogue of Tempel et al. (2017), while regular groups are drawn from the SDSS DR7 group catalogue of Lim et al. (2017); the two catalogues were matched through SDSS object identifiers to define the Lim–Tempel working catalogue. Compact groups are selected from the modified Hickson compact-group catalogue of Díaz-Giménez et al. (2018). Starting from the reliable HM-CGs with exactly four members, we retain only systems in which all galaxies are present in the Lim–Tempel catalogue and impose the volume- and luminosity-complete limits  $0.005 < z_{\text{BGG}} < 0.0452$  and  $M_{r,\text{BGG}} \leq -21.81$ , with all 4 galaxies lying within 3 magnitudes of the brightest group galaxy. This defines the parent CG<sub>4</sub> sample of 78 compact groups. The regular-group comparison samples are built from Lim–Tempel groups satisfying the same redshift and BGG-luminosity limits, with at least 4 members and at

least 3 satellites within 3 magnitudes of the BGG. From this parent control catalogue, we define RG<sub>4</sub> groups as regular groups with exactly four members, excluding systems identical to a CG<sub>4</sub>, and we additionally use the Control<sub>4B</sub> and Control<sub>4C</sub> samples, formed respectively from the 4 brightest galaxies and from the BGG plus its 3 closest projected companions in each parent regular group. The current input catalogues are treated as fixed selected-core catalogues in this paper; after the explicit Lim group 3688 removal, they contain 698 Control<sub>4B</sub> cores and 751 Control<sub>4C</sub> cores. These counts differ because the luminosity-ranked and projected-distance-ranked core definitions select different galaxies and therefore retain different Lim groups. In contrast to our previous study, we remove CGs classified as *split* following Zheng & Shen (2021). This reduces the compact-group sample from 78 to 62 groups. We also remove the systems associated with Lim group 3688 from our Control<sub>4B</sub> and Control<sub>4C</sub> samples. This group contains 6 galaxies with redshifts between 0.032 and 0.034, and 1 with a redshift of 0.048. This group appears to be spurious, and the outlying galaxy, although not the BGG, is selected in both our original Control<sub>4B</sub> and Control<sub>4C</sub> samples, significantly affecting the group velocity dispersion (1979 and 1981 km s<sup>−1</sup>, respectively).

The three regular-group controls serve different physical purposes. RG<sub>4</sub> contains true regular groups with exactly four selected members and is the most direct four-member regular-group comparison. Control<sub>4B</sub> contains the four brightest galaxies in richer regular groups and tests whether the CG<sub>4</sub> population resembles the luminous core of an ordinary group. Control<sub>4C</sub> contains the BGG plus the three closest projected companions and is the most compact-core-like ordinary-group analogue. CG<sub>4</sub> is therefore tested against both equal-membership groups and regular-group cores, rather than against a single control definition.

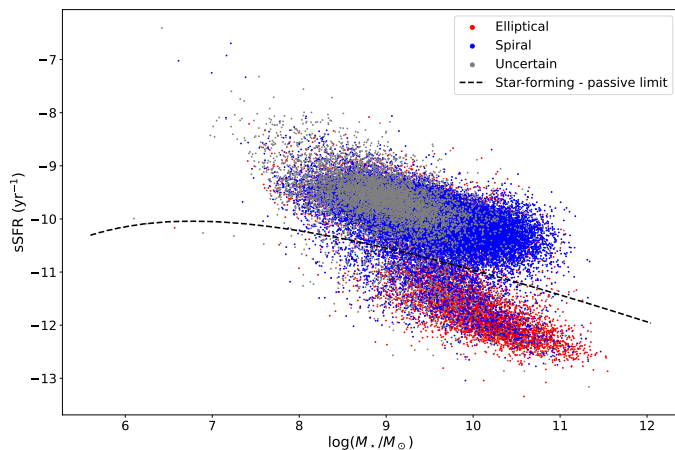
We use SDSS DR 16 to retrieve stellar masses, star formation rates (SFRs), and Galaxy Zoo morphologies (Lintott et al. 2011). We specifically extract the columns `sfr_tot_p50`, `specsfr_tot_p50`, and `lgm_tot_p50` from the `galSpecExtra` table, and `p_el_debiased` and `p_cs_debiased` from the `zooSpec` table. In the SDSS query, `galSpecExtra`, `galSpecLine`, and `zooSpec` are joined to `SpecObj` by `specObjID`, while the photometric object is linked through `SpecObj.bestObjID=PhotoObj.objID`; the queried quantities are then merged onto the CG and control catalogue rows by their stored `objid`.

### 2.2. sSFR classification

We classify galaxies from SDSS total sSFRs using the query reported in Appendix A (Listing 1). Objects with `specsfr_tot_p50` equal to -9999 are labelled quenched; the remaining galaxies are split into passive and star-forming classes with a two-component GMM in the  $\log M_\star$ – $\log$  sSFR plane. BPT/AGN handling and the exact GMM boundary definition are given in Appendix B.

### 2.3. Raw sSFR fractions

The sSFR status for each sample is shown in Table 1. In the raw all-galaxy comparison, Fisher’s exact test gives star-forming-fraction p-values of  $p = 0.449$  versus the Control<sub>4B</sub>



**Fig. 1.** sSFR vs mass, star-forming/passive limit and Zoo morphologies for the SDSS control sample, excluding quenched galaxies.

sample,  $p = 0.068$  versus  $\text{Control}_{4C}$ , and  $p = 4.1 \times 10^{-5}$  versus  $\text{RG}_4$ . We treat these raw tests as descriptive because they do not adjust for stellar mass, rank, or group-scale differences.

The same comparison restricted to BGGs and satellites is also shown in Table 1. For BGGs, the p-values obtained with two-sided Fisher exact test are  $p = 0.585$  against  $\text{Control}_{4B}$ ,  $p = 0.717$  against  $\text{Control}_{4C}$  and  $p = 0.271$  against  $\text{RG}_4$ . For satellites, the corresponding p-values are  $p = 0.28$  against  $\text{Control}_{4B}$ ,  $p = 0.027$  against  $\text{Control}_{4C}$  and  $p = 4.9 \times 10^{-5}$  against  $\text{RG}_4$ . The satellite deficit is clearest in the raw comparison with  $\text{RG}_4$  and is revisited below with adjusted and matched analyses.

## 2.4. Morphology classification

Morphologies are determined via the Galaxy Zoo citizen-science decision tree, in which each galaxy image receives multiple independent volunteer classifications that are aggregated into debiased vote fractions (Lintott et al. 2011). Those fractions are provided in the `zooSpec` table of the SDSS database through the `p_el_debiased` and `p_cs_debiased` columns. We classify a galaxy as “elliptical/smooth” if `p_el_debiased` is greater than 0.5, and as “spiral/features” if `p_cs_debiased` is greater than 0.5. All other cases are classified as “uncertain”. These are vote-fraction classes, not a full structural decomposition. In particular, the catalogue used here does not provide a clean E/S0 separation, so references below to elliptical or early-type galaxies should be read as Galaxy Zoo smooth/early-type proxies rather than as a bulge-disc structural classification.

## 2.5. Galaxy sizes

Our primary galaxy-size measure is the circular half-light radius of the pure Sérsic fit in the  $r$  band,  $R_{\text{chl},r}$ , from the bulge+disk decomposition catalogue of Simard et al. (2011). These are PSF-convolved GIM2D fits with re-derived sky levels and deblending designed with crowded fields in mind, which is the relevant regime for compact-group photometry, so the fitted sizes are corrected for seeing. The catalogue is keyed to SDSS DR7 identifiers; we

therefore bridge our DR16 objects to their DR7 counterparts through the SkyServer SpecDR7 cross-match table. Two guards protect this bridge: rows in which the Simard redshift differs from the catalogue redshift by more than 0.005 are treated as wrong matches and their structural values are dropped (16 rows), and rows in which two distinct catalogue galaxies of the same group resolve to a single DR7 identifier are treated as blended DR7 detections and dropped (0 rows). The Simard sizes are tabulated in kpc under the catalogue’s own cosmology; we convert them back to angular sizes with the catalogue plate scale and then to proper kpc with the same Planck15 conversion used for every other projected quantity in this paper.

As a secondary size measure we use the SDSS Petrosian radii `petroR50_r` and `petroR90_r`, which also define the concentration index  $C = R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$ . Petrosian radii are not corrected for seeing, and the SDSS Petrosian aperture misses a profile-dependent fraction of the flux, roughly 20 per cent for an  $n = 4$  profile, which biases  $R_{50,r}$  low for concentrated galaxies (Blanton et al. 2001; Graham et al. 2005) – precisely the smooth/early-type-like population in which  $\text{CG}_4$  is enhanced. The Petrosian measure is nevertheless retained because it is model-independent, essentially fully available, and provides the like-for-like bridge to the compact-group size study of Coenda et al. (2012). All sizes are required to lie between 0.1 and 50 kpc after re-conversion; Sérsic fits pegged at the GIM2D bounds ( $n_g \leq 0.55$  or  $n_g \geq 7.9$ ; 65 galaxies) are excluded from the primary sample, and Petrosian entries must satisfy  $R_{50,r} > 0$ ,  $R_{90,r} > R_{50,r}$ , and a finite positive uncertainty. The completeness of both measures, and its difference between  $\text{CG}_4$  and the controls, is audited in Sect. 5.9.

## 2.6. Statistical strategy

The analyses are organized hierarchically. Raw tables and exact tests provide descriptive baseline comparisons. Fisher or Barnard exact tests are used for two-sample categorical comparisons depending on the table structure, while rank-sum or bootstrap comparisons are used for distributional and median differences. Spearman and Pearson correlations are used only as diagnostics of monotonic or linear trends; when the coefficients are small, we interpret them as weak even if the p-values are formally small. Holm or Benjamini–Hochberg corrections are applied where multiple related tests are performed. The primary robustness layer consists of mass-, rank-, and environment-adjusted binomial models with group-clustered standard errors, followed by one-to-one matched control comparisons. Colours, AGN-like fractions,  $\text{H}\alpha$  equivalent widths, magnitude gaps, crossing-time trends, projected phase space, and the pairwise tidal index are secondary diagnostics. The main conclusions below rely on signals that survive the adjusted and matched analyses, not on isolated exploratory tests.

# 3. Baseline population differences

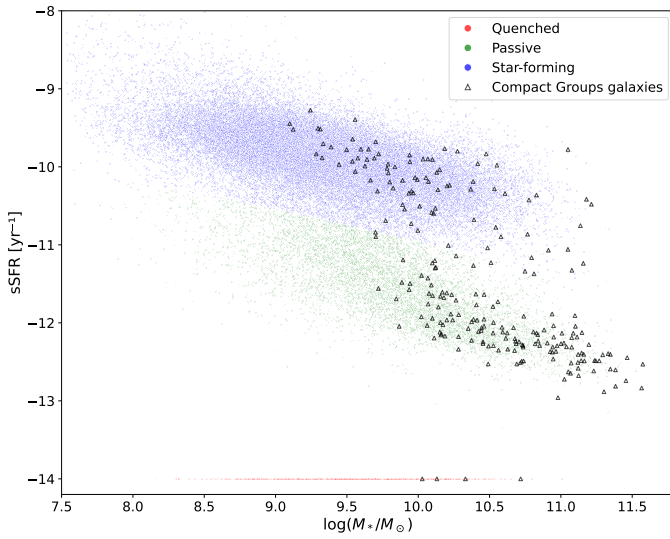
## 3.1. Raw morphology fractions

The morphologies obtained for each sample are shown in Table 2. Barnard’s two-sided exact tests were used to compare the fraction of each morphology between  $\text{CG}_4$  and each control sample. The resulting p-values are  $p = 1.4 \times 10^{-3}$  for ellipticals and  $p = 1.2 \times 10^{-3}$  for spirals versus the  $\text{Control}_{4B}$



| Sample                |            | Quenched    | Passive       | Star-forming   |
|-----------------------|------------|-------------|---------------|----------------|
| CG <sub>4</sub>       |            | 18 (7.3 %)  | 146 (58.9 %)  | 84 (33.9 %)    |
|                       | BGG        | 6 (9.7 %)   | 45 (72.6 %)   | 11 (17.7 %)    |
|                       | Satellites | 12 (6.5 %)  | 101 (54.3 %)  | 73 (39.2 %)    |
| Control <sub>4B</sub> |            | 180 (6.4 %) | 1594 (57.1 %) | 1018 (36.5 %)  |
|                       | BGG        | 58 (8.3 %)  | 533 (76.4 %)  | 107 (15.3 %)   |
|                       | Satellites | 122 (5.8 %) | 1061 (50.7 %) | 911 (43.5 %)   |
| Control <sub>4C</sub> |            | 190 (6.3 %) | 1618 (53.9 %) | 1196 (39.8 %)  |
|                       | BGG        | 65 (8.7 %)  | 568 (75.6 %)  | 118 (15.7 %)   |
|                       | Satellites | 125 (5.5 %) | 1050 (46.6 %) | 1078 (47.8 %)  |
| RG <sub>4</sub>       |            | 5 (2.2 %)   | 101 (45.1 %)  | 118 (52.7 %)   |
|                       | BGG        | 3 (5.4 %)   | 38 (67.9 %)   | 15 (26.8 %)    |
|                       | Satellites | 2 (1.2 %)   | 63 (37.5 %)   | 103 (61.3 %)   |
| SDSS selection        |            | 634 (1.2 %) | 7705 (14.7 %) | 44192 (84.1 %) |

**Table 1.** Number of galaxies in each sSFR status for each sample.



**Fig. 2.** sSFR and morphologies of galaxies in CG<sub>4</sub> and our SDSS selection. Quenched galaxies are represented at an arbitrary low value of  $10^{-14.0} \text{ yr}^{-1}$ .

sample,  $p = 3.3 \times 10^{-3}$  and  $p = 0.034$  versus Control<sub>4C</sub> and  $p < 10^{-6}$  and  $p < 10^{-6}$  versus RG<sub>4</sub>. The galaxies in CG<sub>4</sub> systems, which we identified as cores of richer groups in (Tricottet et al. 2025), show a robust raw excess of elliptical/smooth classifications and a deficit of spiral/features classifications. Figure 2 displays sSFR versus stellar mass for galaxies in the SDSS selection and in CG<sub>4</sub>.

### 3.2. Morphology versus sSFR

Among star-forming CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies, 58 are classified as spiral (84.1% after removing galaxies with uncertain morphology) and 11 are classified as elliptical (15.9% after removing galaxies with uncertain morphology). The corresponding numbers are 809 spiral galaxies (88.4%) and 106 elliptical galaxies (11.6%) for Control<sub>4B</sub>, 851 spiral galaxies (84.3%) and 159 elliptical galaxies (15.7%) for Control<sub>4C</sub>, and 91 spiral galaxies (91%) and 9 elliptical galaxies (9%) for RG<sub>4</sub>. The probabilities that these fractions are drawn from the same distribution, estimated with Barnard two-sided exact test, are  $p = 0.287$  against Control<sub>4B</sub>,  $p = 0.969$

against Control<sub>4C</sub>, and  $p = 0.186$  against RG<sub>4</sub>. We therefore find neither a significant excess nor a deficit of star-forming elliptical galaxies in CG<sub>4</sub> relative to any control sample.

When restricting the comparison to BGGs, we find 36 elliptical BGGs (58.1% of the BGGs) and 17 spiral BGGs (27.4%) in CG<sub>4</sub>. The corresponding numbers are 405 elliptical BGGs (58.0%) and 195 spiral BGGs (27.9%) in Control<sub>4B</sub>, 424 elliptical BGGs (56.5%) and 216 spiral BGGs (28.8%) in Control<sub>4C</sub>, and 21 elliptical BGGs (37.5%) and 26 spiral BGGs (46.4%) in RG<sub>4</sub>. The p-values obtained with two-sided Fisher exact test are 1.00 against Control<sub>4B</sub>, 0.88 against Control<sub>4C</sub> and 0.03 against RG<sub>4</sub>. Thus, BGG morphologies differ between CG<sub>4</sub> and RG<sub>4</sub>: CG<sub>4</sub> BGGs have a higher elliptical fraction than RG<sub>4</sub> BGGs.

### 3.3. Population medians by sSFR class

Tables 3–5 summarize the typical stellar masses, absolute magnitudes, and sSFRs of passive and star-forming galaxies, including splits by the sSFR class of the BGG. These medians are descriptive and mainly show that star-formation class is entangled with stellar mass and luminosity, motivating the adjusted models below.

### 3.4. Main sequence

We model the star-forming main sequence as a function of stellar mass using polynomial orders 1–4; the polynomial-order comparison is shown in Appendix Fig. C.5. The diagnostic shown there is the residual RMS scatter, not a formal reduced  $\chi^2$ , because no per-galaxy uncertainty model is used. We adopt order 2 because it is the lowest-order model with the smallest five-fold cross-validated RMS scatter (0.30526 dex, compared with 0.30562 dex for order 1). We then use order 2 to compute the residual of each star-forming galaxy with respect to the main sequence, and show their distributions in Fig. 3. A positive residual means higher sSFR at fixed stellar mass relative to the fitted star-forming main sequence.

The median main-sequence residual of CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies is:

- marginally different from that of Control<sub>4B</sub>, with a median offset of  $\Delta = 0.055$  ( $0.027 \leq \Delta \leq 0.098$ , bootstrap), corresponding to  $p = 0.056$ .

| Sample                | Elliptical/smooth     | Spiral/features       | Uncertain            |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|
| CG <sub>4</sub>       | 124 (50.0 %)          | 86 (34.7 %)           | 38 (15.3 %)          |
| Control <sub>4B</sub> | 1106 (39.6 %)         | 1266 (45.3 %)         | 420 (15.0 %)         |
| Control <sub>4C</sub> | 1215 (40.4 %)         | 1249 (41.6 %)         | 540 (18.0 %)         |
| RG <sub>4</sub>       | 60 (26.8 %)           | 129 (57.6 %)          | 35 (15.6 %)          |
| <i>SDSS selection</i> | <i>10091 (19.2 %)</i> | <i>34715 (66.1 %)</i> | <i>7725 (14.7 %)</i> |

**Table 2.** Number of galaxies in each Galaxy Zoo vote-fraction morphology proxy for each sample.

| Sample                | $\log_{10}(\text{sSFR} [\text{yr}^{-1}])$ |                   | $M_r$             |                   | $\log(M_{\star}/M_{\odot})$ |                  |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------|------------------|
|                       | Passive                                   | Star-forming      | Passive           | Star-forming      | Passive                     | Star-forming     |
| CG <sub>4</sub>       | $-12.08 \pm 0.03$                         | $-10.19 \pm 0.07$ | $-21.16 \pm 0.14$ | $-20.4 \pm 0.14$  | $10.64 \pm 0.07$            | $10.05 \pm 0.05$ |
| Control <sub>4B</sub> | $-12.1 \pm 0.01$                          | $-10.31 \pm 0.02$ | $-21.52 \pm 0.04$ | $-20.75 \pm 0.04$ | $10.79 \pm 0.01$            | $10.24 \pm 0.02$ |
| Control <sub>4C</sub> | $-11.92 \pm 0.02$                         | $-10.16 \pm 0.02$ | $-20.81 \pm 0.07$ | $-19.93 \pm 0.04$ | $10.47 \pm 0.03$            | $9.82 \pm 0.03$  |
| RG <sub>4</sub>       | $-11.91 \pm 0.07$                         | $-10.16 \pm 0.07$ | $-21.11 \pm 0.25$ | $-20.32 \pm 0.12$ | $10.62 \pm 0.08$            | $9.97 \pm 0.09$  |

**Table 3.** Median values of galaxy properties for passive and star-forming populations in each sample. Uncertainties are estimated by bootstrapping (10 000 iterations).

| Sample                | $\log_{10}(\text{sSFR} [\text{yr}^{-1}])$ |                   | $M_r$             |                   | $\log(M_{\star}/M_{\odot})$ |                  |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------|------------------|
|                       | Passive                                   | Star-forming      | Passive           | Star-forming      | Passive                     | Star-forming     |
| CG <sub>4</sub>       | $-11.53 \pm 0.09$                         | $-10.85 \pm 0.29$ | $-20.93 \pm 0.11$ | $-20.77 \pm 0.32$ | $10.46 \pm 0.06$            | $10.32 \pm 0.12$ |
| Control <sub>4B</sub> | $-11.53 \pm 0.03$                         | $-10.86 \pm 0.06$ | $-21.25 \pm 0.03$ | $-21.12 \pm 0.07$ | $10.61 \pm 0.02$            | $10.46 \pm 0.04$ |
| Control <sub>4C</sub> | $-11.3 \pm 0.03$                          | $-10.62 \pm 0.06$ | $-20.42 \pm 0.05$ | $-20.55 \pm 0.08$ | $10.22 \pm 0.02$            | $10.15 \pm 0.06$ |
| RG <sub>4</sub>       | $-11.14 \pm 0.19$                         | $-10.58 \pm 0.16$ | $-20.69 \pm 0.14$ | $-20.74 \pm 0.27$ | $10.32 \pm 0.07$            | $10.19 \pm 0.12$ |

**Table 4.** Median values of various quantities for galaxies according to the sSFR class of their BGG (BGG included). Uncertainties are estimated by bootstrapping (10 000 iterations).

- significantly different from that of Control<sub>4C</sub>, with a median offset of  $\Delta = 0.082$  ( $0.061 \leq \Delta \leq 0.121$ , bootstrap), corresponding to  $p = 0.011$ .
- not significantly different from that of RG<sub>4</sub>, with a median offset of  $\Delta = 0.046$  ( $-0.037 \leq \Delta \leq 0.098$ , bootstrap), corresponding to  $p = 0.532$ .

Because the raw residual comparison and the matched comparison below condition on different covariate structures, and because the apparent offset changes in strength and sign after matching, we treat SFMS residuals as a secondary diagnostic rather than as evidence for a robust compact-group star-formation offset.

Within CG<sub>4</sub>, the star-forming main-sequence offsets of the Embedded, Isolated and Predominant classes remain statistically consistent with one another.

## 4. Environmental and group-scale diagnostics

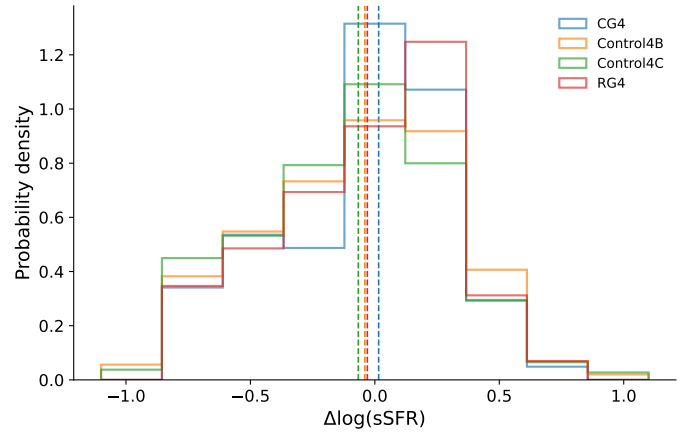
### 4.1. Distance to the BGG

We also compare the sSFR of satellite galaxies with their distance to the BGG, expressed both in projected kpc and in units of  $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$ .

Significant monotonic trends are detected in the following cases.

In CG<sub>4</sub>, sSFR correlates with projected distance to the BGG with Spearman coefficient  $\rho_s = 0.24$  for 177 satellites ( $p = 1.2 \times 10^{-3}$ ) and Pearson coefficient  $r = 0.21$  ( $p = 4.1 \times 10^{-3}$ ).

In Control<sub>4B</sub>, sSFR correlates with distance to the BGG normalized by  $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$  with Spearman coefficient  $\rho_s = 0.08$


**Fig. 3.** Main-sequence residual distributions for the star-forming galaxies in each sample.

for 1991 satellites ( $p = 3.6 \times 10^{-4}$ ) and Pearson coefficient  $r = 0.08$  ( $p = 2.3 \times 10^{-4}$ ).

In Control<sub>4C</sub>, sSFR correlates with projected distance to the BGG with Spearman coefficient  $\rho_s = 0.25$  for 2143 satellites ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ) and Pearson coefficient  $r = 0.20$  ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ).

In Control<sub>4C</sub>, sSFR correlates with distance to the BGG normalized by  $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$  with Spearman coefficient  $\rho_s = 0.10$  for 2143 satellites ( $p = 4.6 \times 10^{-6}$ ) and Pearson coefficient  $r = 0.09$  ( $p = 1.8 \times 10^{-5}$ ).

The supporting distance plots are shown in Appendix Figs. C.6 and C.7.

| Sample    | $\log_{10}(\text{sSFR} [\text{yr}^{-1}])$ |                   | $M_r$             |                   | $\log(M_\star/M_\odot)$ |                  |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------------|------------------|
|           | Passive                                   | Star-forming      | Passive           | Star-forming      | Passive                 | Star-forming     |
| CG4       | $-11.23 \pm 0.16$                         | $-10.92 \pm 0.48$ | $-20.45 \pm 0.13$ | $-20.34 \pm 0.18$ | $10.22 \pm 0.05$        | $10.09 \pm 0.06$ |
| Control4B | $-11.26 \pm 0.06$                         | $-10.91 \pm 0.13$ | $-20.9 \pm 0.03$  | $-20.75 \pm 0.06$ | $10.43 \pm 0.02$        | $10.3 \pm 0.03$  |
| Control4C | $-10.96 \pm 0.04$                         | $-10.6 \pm 0.07$  | $-19.8 \pm 0.04$  | $-20.02 \pm 0.10$ | $9.91 \pm 0.02$         | $9.89 \pm 0.07$  |
| RG4       | $-10.82 \pm 0.19$                         | $-10.61 \pm 0.22$ | $-20.23 \pm 0.16$ | $-20.3 \pm 0.13$  | $10.09 \pm 0.08$        | $10 \pm 0.13$    |

**Table 5.** Median values of various quantities for galaxies according to the sSFR class of their BGG (satellites only). Uncertainties are estimated by bootstrapping (10 000 iterations).

#### 4.2. Dominance

We split groups into dominated systems, where the BGG contributes more than 60% of the group luminosity, and non-dominated systems. This split does not produce a strong compact-group signal by itself: CG<sub>4</sub> shows no significant dominated/non-dominated difference after the Benjamini–Hochberg false-discovery-rate (FDR) correction. Here  $p_{\text{adj}}$  denotes the FDR-adjusted p-value, and Cliff’s  $\delta$  is a rank-based effect size ranging from -1 to 1.

Across the control and reference samples, the clearest binary separation is instead in group luminosity. Dominated systems have lower  $L_{\text{group}}$  than their non-dominated counterparts: Control<sub>4B</sub> gives  $9.1 \times 10^{10}$  versus  $1.28 \times 10^{11} L_\odot$  ( $p_{\text{adj}} < 10^{-6}$ ,  $\delta = -0.55$ ); Control<sub>4C</sub> gives  $8.49 \times 10^{10}$  versus  $9.54 \times 10^{10} L_\odot$  ( $p_{\text{adj}} < 10^{-6}$ ,  $\delta = -0.25$ ); and RG<sub>4</sub> gives  $7.09 \times 10^{10}$  versus  $9.82 \times 10^{10} L_\odot$  ( $p_{\text{adj}} = 7.8 \times 10^{-5}$ ,  $\delta = -0.59$ ). The negative  $\delta$  values mean that dominated groups tend to occupy the lower-luminosity side of each comparison.

The spiral-fraction correlations show a broader environmental pattern rather than a clean dominated/non-dominated dichotomy. The most coherent set appears in Control<sub>4C</sub>, where  $S_{\text{frac}}$  increases with  $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$  in both dominated and non-dominated groups ( $\rho_S = 0.38$ ,  $p < 10^{-6}$  and  $\rho_S = 0.35$ ,  $p < 10^{-6}$ ), while weaker negative trends are found with  $\sigma_v$  and  $L_{\text{group}}$ . Control<sub>4B</sub> contributes only weaker non-dominated-group correlations. In CG<sub>4</sub>, the significant trends occur in small subsets, with  $S_{\text{frac}}$  decreasing with  $L_{\text{group}}$  among dominated groups ( $\rho_S = -0.50$ , 36 groups) and with  $\Delta V_{\text{BGG}}/\sigma_v$  among non-dominated groups ( $\rho_S = -0.53$ , 26 groups); we therefore treat these as supporting diagnostics rather than the main dominance result. The full distributional and correlation diagnostics are shown in Appendix Figs. C.8 and C.9.

#### 4.3. Morphology and domination

When we further split the samples by domination and by the morphology of the BGG, significant effects only appear in

Control<sub>4B</sub> dominated groups, where the median satellite spiral fraction is 1.00 for spiral BGGs and 0.67 for elliptical BGGs. The association between BGG morphology and satellite spiral fraction has a group-level odds ratio of 1.842 ( $p = 0.01$ ) in this sample; the same within-sample contrast under a satellite-level clustered uncertainty treatment gives an odds ratio of 1.842 ( $p = 0.02$ );

Control<sub>4C</sub> dominated groups, where the median satellite spiral fraction is 0.67 for spiral BGGs and 0.50 for elliptical BGGs. The association between BGG morphology and satellite spiral fraction has a group-level odds ratio of 1.840 ( $p = 2.1 \times 10^{-5}$ ) in this sample; the same within-sample con-

trast under a satellite-level clustered uncertainty treatment gives an odds ratio of 1.840 ( $p = 2.7 \times 10^{-5}$ ).

#### 4.4. Morphology versus Zheng–Shen class, magnitude gap, and BGG dominance

We next test whether the E/Sp morphology mix is associated with three group-level descriptors: the Zheng–Shen compact-group class, the first–second magnitude gap  $\Delta m_{12} = M_{r,2} - M_{r,1}$ , and the continuous BGG luminosity fraction  $f_{L,\text{BGG}} = L_{\text{BGG}}/L_{\text{group}}$ . These tests use only the existing Galaxy Zoo elliptical/smooth and spiral/features classes; uncertain morphologies are excluded from the binary fits. We run the tests separately for all galaxies, BGGs only, and satellites only, so that any trend driven by the BGG itself is not folded into the satellite result. For satellites,  $f_{L,\text{BGG}}$  mechanically includes the satellite luminosity in the group-luminosity denominator, so any satellite-level trend with  $f_{L,\text{BGG}}$  is partly definitional; we therefore report the satellite models with a stellar-mass control.

The magnitude-gap and BGG-luminosity-fraction quantities are available for all 118 CG<sub>4</sub>+RG<sub>4</sub> groups used in this test. The Zheng–Shen class is available only for compact groups. Split systems are absent from the current CG<sub>4</sub> sample because they are removed before the paper analysis, and no corresponding Zheng–Shen class is defined for the RG<sub>4</sub> catalogue used here. We therefore report the RG<sub>4</sub> class test as unavailable, while retaining RG<sub>4</sub> in the  $\Delta m_{12}$  and  $f_{L,\text{BGG}}$  comparisons.

Overall, these tests provide little evidence that the E/Sp mix is driven by Zheng–Shen class, magnitude gap, or BGG luminosity fraction. The few marginal associations are therefore treated as descriptive diagnostics rather than as robust secondary trends.

For the Zheng–Shen compact-group class, no CG<sub>4</sub> association reaches the conventional 5% significance threshold. The closest case is the satellite-only test, which is treated as marginal and descriptive. Because the Zheng–Shen class is not defined for the RG<sub>4</sub> catalogue, we do not attempt an RG<sub>4</sub> class comparison.

For  $\Delta m_{12}$ , no statistically significant morphology trend is found in CG<sub>4</sub> or RG<sub>4</sub>, whether the fit is run for all galaxies, BGGs only, or satellites only. The same conclusion holds for  $f_{L,\text{BGG}}$ : no fitted trend reaches  $p < 0.05$ . The CG<sub>4</sub>–RG<sub>4</sub> interaction models detect no significant difference in the morphology–dominance relation for either  $\Delta m_{12}$  or  $f_{L,\text{BGG}}$ , across all galaxies, BGGs only, and satellites only. A class interaction is not defined because the Zheng–Shen compact-group class has no RG<sub>4</sub> counterpart in the present catalogue. Across the morphology–class, morphology–gap, morphology–luminosity-fraction, and interaction tests, no

| Zheng–Shen class | All CG <sub>4</sub> E/Sp | CG <sub>4</sub> BGG E/Sp | CG <sub>4</sub> satellites E/Sp |
|------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Split            | 0/0                      | 0/0                      | 0/0                             |
| Isolated         | 7/11                     | 3/1                      | 4/10                            |
| Predominant      | 41/22                    | 11/5                     | 30/17                           |
| Embedded         | 76/53                    | 22/11                    | 54/42                           |

**Table 6.** Elliptical/smooth and spiral/features counts by Zheng–Shen class for the CG<sub>4</sub> sample. Uncertain morphologies are excluded. Split systems have zero counts because they were removed by the existing non-split CG<sub>4</sub> sample definition.

| Subset          | Sample          | Class test  | $\Delta m_{12}$ model | $f_{L,BGG}$ model    |
|-----------------|-----------------|-------------|-----------------------|----------------------|
| all galaxies    | CG <sub>4</sub> | $p = 0.137$ | OR 1.42, $p = 0.160$  | OR 1.29, $p = 0.076$ |
| all galaxies    | RG <sub>4</sub> | not defined | OR 1.33, $p = 0.220$  | OR 1.09, $p = 0.540$ |
| BGGs only       | CG <sub>4</sub> | $p = 1.000$ | OR 1.77, $p = 0.426$  | OR 1.68, $p = 0.174$ |
| BGGs only       | RG <sub>4</sub> | not defined | OR 1.58, $p = 0.312$  | OR 1.21, $p = 0.520$ |
| satellites only | CG <sub>4</sub> | $p = 0.066$ | OR 1.28, $p = 0.342$  | OR 1.18, $p = 0.318$ |
| satellites only | RG <sub>4</sub> | not defined | OR 1.41, $p = 0.342$  | OR 1.12, $p = 0.584$ |

**Table 7.** Tests of the E-vs-Sp morphology mix against compact-group class, magnitude gap, and BGG luminosity fraction. The continuous columns report the available adjusted logistic model for  $P(E)$ ; all-galaxy and satellite fits use group-clustered standard errors. Odds ratios are reported per magnitude for  $\Delta m_{12}$  and per 0.1 increase in luminosity fraction for  $f_{L,BGG}$ .

result remains significant after Benjamini–Hochberg FDR control.

#### 4.5. Crossing time

The crossing-time diagnostic mainly separates systems by dynamical scale rather than by luminosity alone. Shorter  $t_{\text{cross}}$  systems have larger virial mass-to-light ratios and virial masses: the correlations with  $\log(M_{\text{VT}}/L_r)$  and  $\log(M_{\text{VT}})$  are  $\rho_S = -0.39$  ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ) and  $\rho_S = -0.33$  ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ), respectively, over 816 groups. By contrast, the relation with total group luminosity is formally detected but very weak ( $\rho_S = 0.08$ ). We therefore read  $t_{\text{cross}}$  as a dynamical compactness indicator tied primarily to virial mass and mass-to-light ratio, with little independent leverage from  $L_{\text{group}}$ . Appendix Figs. C.10–C.12 show the corresponding projected and three-dimensional trends.

#### 4.6. Optical colours

We derive the  $(u-r)$ ,  $(u-g)$ ,  $(g-r)$  and  $(r-i)$  colours from the matched SDSS photometry. The retained colour-analysis matches include 110 of 248 galaxies in CG<sub>4</sub>, 931 of 2792 galaxies in Control<sub>4B</sub>, 1478 of 3004 galaxies in Control<sub>4C</sub>, 102 of 224 galaxies in RG<sub>4</sub>. This stricter subset differs from the availability audit in Fig. C.29: the figure’s colour row only requires the four derived SDSS colour columns to be present in the final catalogue, giving 217 of 248 CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies, whereas the colour analysis here also requires successful matched-photometry retention and the covariates used below. Stellar mass is a confounding variable in colour comparisons (Alpaslan et al. 2015); we therefore model each colour jointly with  $\log(M_{\star}/M_{\odot})$  rather than comparing unadjusted colour distributions.

The colour-analysis subset is not representative of the full galaxy catalogues: matched galaxies are systematically less massive, more actively star-forming, and more frequently satellites than unmatched galaxies. The fractions retained in this stricter colour-analysis subset are 44.4% in CG<sub>4</sub>, 33.3% in Control<sub>4B</sub>, 49.2% in Control<sub>4C</sub>, 45.5% in

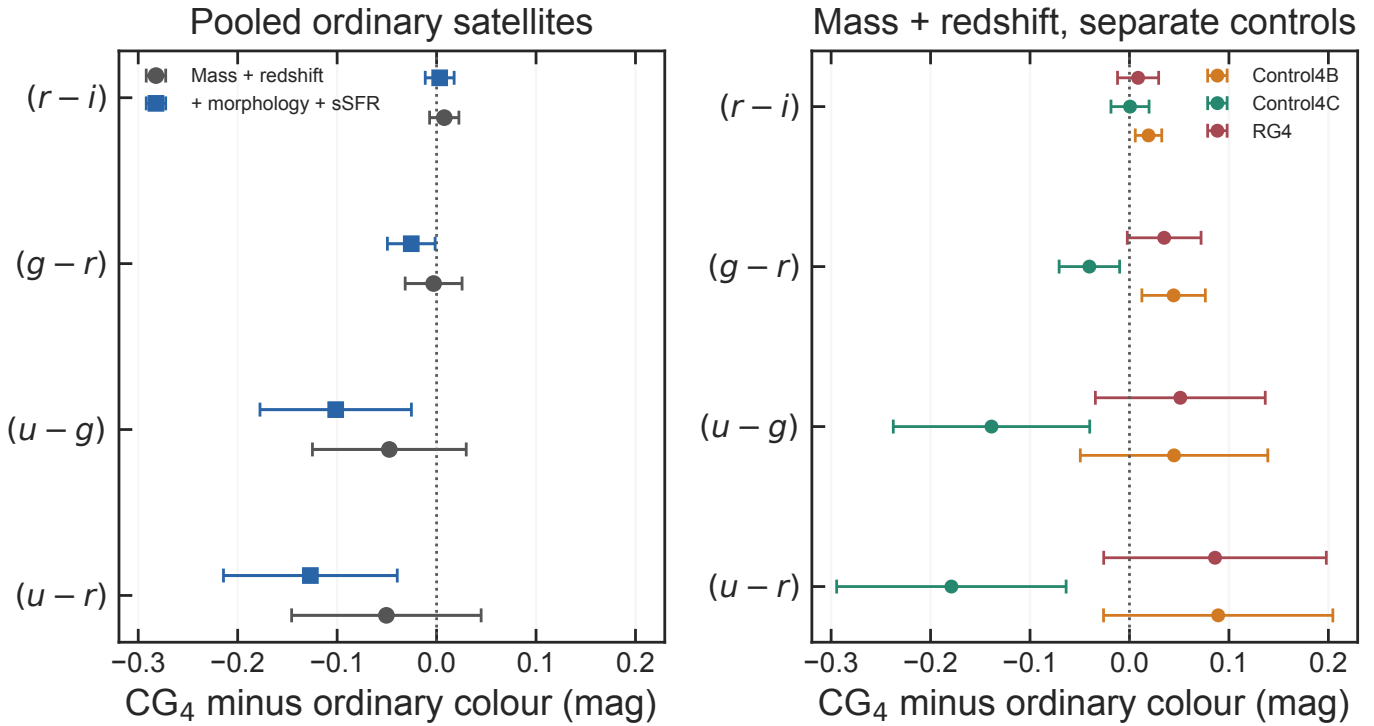
RG<sub>4</sub>. The colour analysis is therefore useful as a secondary diagnostic, but it cannot carry the main interpretation by itself.

The raw catalogue colour–mass fits indicate that CG<sub>4</sub> does not simply follow the same colour–mass relation as every comparison sample: common slopes are rejected in all four colours, with the significant directional slope differences concentrated in the bluer colours and dependent on the adopted comparison catalogue. In the satellite-only comparison, the fitted offsets and slopes likewise depend on the control definition. These tests motivate the robustness analysis rather than establishing a stand-alone compact-group colour effect.

We therefore refit the satellite colours with cluster-robust standard errors, using catalogue-qualified group identifiers. In the pooled comparison adjusted only for stellar mass and redshift, none of the four CG<sub>4</sub> coefficients is significantly negative after Holm correction. After additionally controlling for morphology and sSFR class, negative coefficients appear in  $(u-r)$  ( $\Delta = -0.127$  mag, Holm-corrected  $p = 0.018$ ) and  $(u-g)$  ( $\Delta = -0.101$  mag, Holm-corrected  $p = 0.027$ ). However, these adjusted coefficients are control-sample dependent, and they do not persist within the sSFR or morphology splits. The data therefore do not localize the colour effect to the star-forming spiral population expected for a simple interaction-triggered star-formation scenario.

Residual colour trends with projected BGG-centric distance are consistent with stronger processing near the group centre and a less processed outer population, but these trends use the same biased colour subset and are treated as exploratory. The group-level BGG–satellite colour concordance is similarly secondary: redder BGGs tend to have redder mean satellite populations in the combined group sample, but the CG<sub>4</sub> slope is not a robustly distinct population-level signature. Detailed colour–mass, satellite, radial, BGG–satellite, and domination diagnostics are shown in Appendix Figs. C.13–C.17. Figure 4 summarizes the model and control-sample dependence that motivates our interpretation: the present data do not establish a robust global blue or red offset for CG<sub>4</sub> satellites.





**Fig. 4.** Robustness of the satellite colour coefficients. Left: pooled ordinary-group comparison before and after controlling for morphology and sSFR class. Right: mass- and redshift-adjusted comparisons against each control catalogue separately. Points show the  $CG_4$  minus ordinary coefficient and bars show 95% confidence intervals; negative values indicate bluer  $CG_4$  satellites.

## 5. Robustness: what drives the compact-group differences?

The previous sections establish that  $CG_4$  galaxies differ from the control catalogues in their population mix, especially in morphology and in the star-forming fraction of satellites. We now ask whether these differences survive after controlling for stellar mass, rank and available group-scale quantities, and whether they are better interpreted as compact-group-specific evolution, preprocessing in dense halo cores, or catalogue-selection effects.

### 5.1. Mass-, rank- and environment-adjusted galaxy properties

We fit binomial models to the combined galaxy catalogues, standardizing the continuous predictors and using group-clustered standard errors. The common adjustment set includes stellar mass, redshift, satellite/BGG rank, group luminosity and velocity dispersion when sufficiently complete.

For passive status, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 1.20, with 95% confidence interval [0.88, 1.63] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.485$ .

For passive satellite status, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 1.31, with 95% confidence interval [0.95, 1.80] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.390$ .

For star-forming satellite status, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 0.76, with 95% confidence interval [0.56, 1.05] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.390$ .

For elliptical morphology, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 1.62, with 95% confidence interval [1.21, 2.16] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.007$ .

For elliptical satellite morphology, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 1.84, with 95% confidence interval [1.34, 2.53] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.001$ .

For elliptical BGG morphology, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 0.90, with 95% confidence interval [0.46, 1.74] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.751$ .

For spiral morphology, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 0.62, with 95% confidence interval [0.46, 0.83] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.007$ .

For spiral satellite morphology, the  $CG_4$  odds ratio is 0.54, with 95% confidence interval [0.39, 0.75] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.001$ .

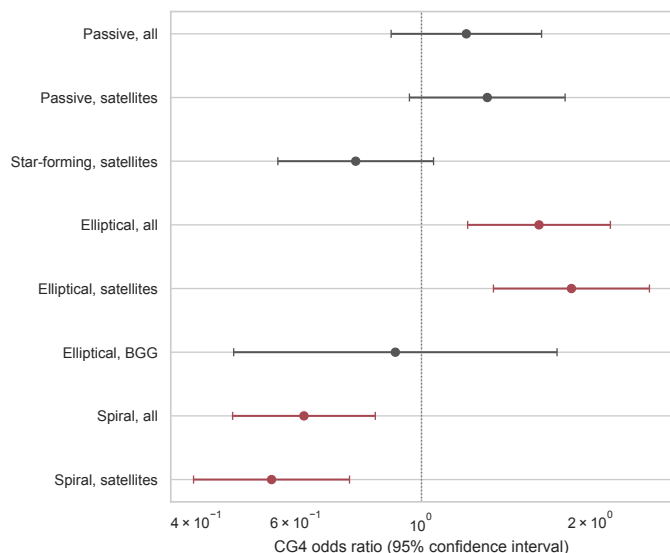
Compact-group membership therefore remains independently associated with morphology after the available adjustments:  $CG_4$  galaxies have a higher probability of being elliptical and a lower probability of being spiral. In contrast, the adjusted passive and star-forming satellite coefficients are weaker and do not provide evidence for an instantaneous star-formation difference that remains significant after correction.

The adjusted morphology signal is primarily carried by satellites rather than BGGs: the satellite-only models give a smooth/elliptical odds ratio of 1.84 and a spiral/features odds ratio of 0.54, whereas the BGG smooth/elliptical coefficient is not significant after adjustment (OR 0.90; Holm-corrected  $p = 0.751$ ).

### 5.2. Morphology robustness to projected crowding

Because Galaxy Zoo morphology is image-based, the  $CG_4$  smooth/elliptical excess must be checked against projected crowding and deblending. We therefore repeat the morphology comparison after excluding galaxies whose nearest





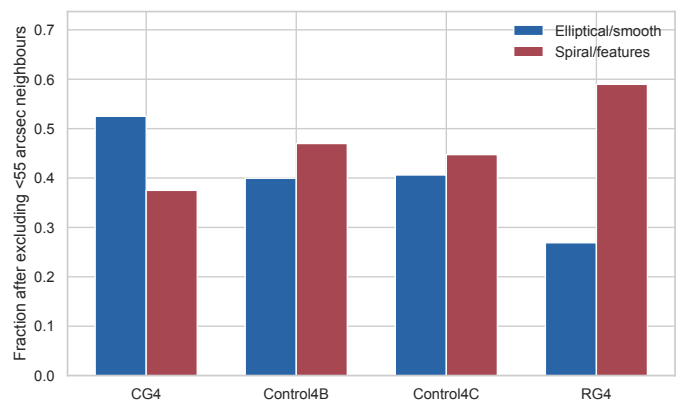
**Fig. 5.** Adjusted CG<sub>4</sub> odds ratios for star-formation and morphology diagnostics, including all-galaxy, satellite-only, and BGG-only morphology rows. Bars show 95% confidence intervals; the vertical line marks equal odds.

projected neighbour within the catalogue group lies within 55 arcsec. The retained samples contain 200 CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies and 2620 Control<sub>4C</sub> galaxies. After this exclusion, the CG<sub>4</sub> smooth/elliptical fraction is 52.5%, compared with 40.6% in Control<sub>4C</sub>; the CG<sub>4</sub>–Control<sub>4C</sub> exact-test result remains significant ( $p = 0.001$ ). The CG<sub>4</sub> smooth fraction rises relative to the raw full-sample value in Table 2, rather than falling after the closest projected pairs are removed. This argues against the simplest interpretation that the CG<sub>4</sub> smooth excess is produced solely by crowding in the closest pairs.

The complementary close-neighbour-flag model reaches the same qualitative conclusion. After adjusting for the standard covariates and a  $< 55$ -arcsec neighbour flag, the CG<sub>4</sub> smooth/elliptical odds ratio is 1.54 (95% CI [1.14, 2.07];  $p = 0.004$ ). The close-neighbour flag is itself associated with smooth morphology (OR 1.93;  $p = 2.9 \times 10^{-6}$ ), so this test does not prove that all Galaxy Zoo classifications are immune to crowding. It does rule out the simplest closest-pair artifact as the sole origin of the morphology result. Figure 6 shows the corresponding post-exclusion morphology fractions.

### 5.3. Matched-control comparison

We matched 234 of the 248 available CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies one-to-one to 234 ordinary-group galaxies without replacement, requiring common propensity-score support, a 0.2-standard-deviation caliper and exact rank strata. The remaining 14 CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies were excluded because they lay outside the common propensity-score support or exceeded the adopted caliper. The propensity model uses logMstar,  $z$  numeric, rank, log group luminosity, velocity dispersion. Projected distance is retained as a phase-space and interaction diagnostic rather than matched away because it partly defines compactness and has limited overlap. The largest absolute standardized mean difference changed from 0.28 before matching to 0.14 afterwards.



**Fig. 6.** Galaxy Zoo morphology fractions after excluding galaxies with a nearest projected neighbour within 55 arcsec. The CG<sub>4</sub> smooth/elliptical excess persists after this closest-neighbour exclusion.

The matched CG<sub>4</sub>–minus–control difference in passive fraction is 0.098, with 95% bootstrap interval [0.017, 0.175] and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.054$ .

This is suggestive but not formally significant after correction, so we treat the passive-fraction excess as borderline.

The corresponding CG<sub>4</sub>–minus–control difference in star-forming fraction is  $-0.098$ , with 95% bootstrap interval  $[-0.175, -0.017]$  and Holm-corrected  $p = 0.054$ .

The matched CG<sub>4</sub>–minus–control difference in elliptical fraction is 0.197, with 95% bootstrap interval [0.090, 0.303] and Holm-corrected  $p < 10^{-6}$ .

The matched CG<sub>4</sub>–minus–control difference in spiral fraction is  $-0.197$ , with 95% bootstrap interval  $[-0.303, -0.090]$  and Holm-corrected  $p < 10^{-6}$ .

Among matched star-forming galaxies, the residual-sSFR difference is  $-0.096$ , with 95% bootstrap interval  $[-0.221, 0.015]$  and  $p = 0.084$ .

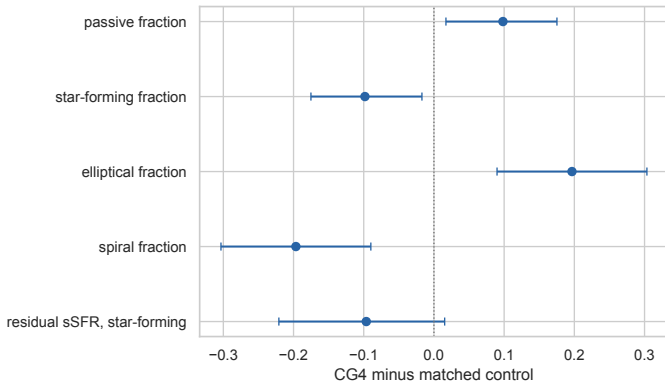
The matched-outcome Holm correction is intentionally conservative: passive/star-forming and elliptical/spiral diagnostics are retained in the same family even though the audit finds that they are exact complements on their complete-case subsets. Using a non-redundant family would not weaken the morphology conclusion.

The main interpretation does not rely on the exact GMM division of the sSFR plane. Repeating the key satellite comparison with a fixed threshold,  $\log_{10}(\text{sSFR}/\text{yr}^{-1}) = -11.0$ , gives CG<sub>4</sub> and RG<sub>4</sub> satellite star-forming fractions of 40.7% and 60.2%, respectively, a CG<sub>4</sub>–RG<sub>4</sub> difference of  $-19.6$  percentage points ( $p = 3.6 \times 10^{-4}$ ). The qualitative hierarchy is unchanged: the morphology result is independent of the sSFR threshold, whereas the passive/star-forming contrast remains more sensitive to modelling choices.

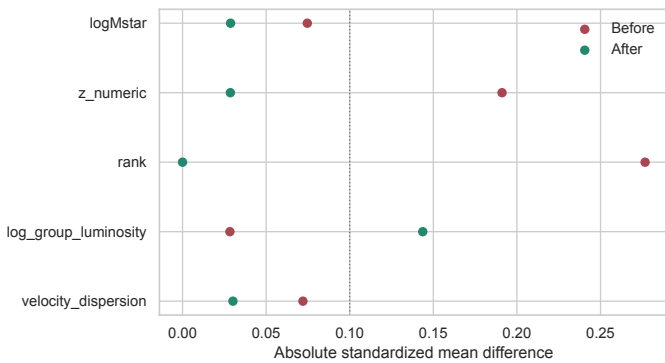
The matched comparison is therefore consistent with the adjusted models: the most robust compact-group signal is morphological, while the passive and star-forming-fraction signals are more model-dependent.

### 5.4. Satellite segregation around the brightest group galaxy

The previous sections show global differences between CG<sub>4</sub> and RG<sub>4</sub> satellites. We now ask whether these differences are concentrated near the BGG, as expected for accelerated evolution in the dense inner group, or whether they persist across the satellite population. The analysis uses



**Fig. 7.**  $\text{CG}_4$ -minus-control effects after one-to-one matching. Bars show 95% bootstrap confidence intervals.



**Fig. 8.** Absolute standardized mean differences before and after matching.

177  $\text{CG}_4$  and 166  $\text{RG}_4$  satellites, excludes rank-1 galaxies, ranks satellites by projected BGG-centric distance, and measures passive and early-type fractions with group-cluster bootstrap uncertainties. When available, we also use  $|\Delta v_{\text{BGG}}|/\sigma_v$ , with  $\Delta v_{\text{BGG}} = c(z_{\text{gal}} - z_{\text{BGG}})/(1 + z_{\text{group}})$ , as a projected phase-space diagnostic. Similar projected phase-space coordinates are often used as observational proxies for satellite infall state or quenching time, but only statistically (Mahajan et al. 2011; Oman & Hudson 2016; Wetzel et al. 2013).

In the innermost satellite-distance bin, the passive fractions are 68.9% for  $\text{CG}_4$  and 48.2% for  $\text{RG}_4$ , a  $\text{CG}_4$ - $\text{RG}_4$  difference of 20.6 percentage points. The corresponding early-type fractions are 65.4% and 35.6%, with a difference of 29.8 percentage points.

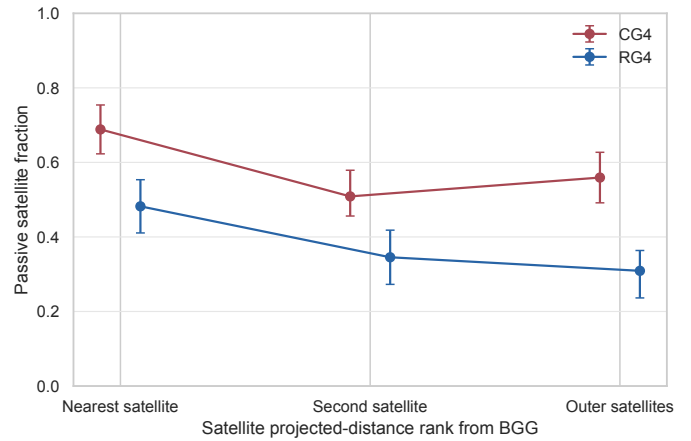
The passive-fraction contrast is similar between the inner and outer distance ranks, so the data do not isolate the  $\text{CG}_4$  offset to the immediate BGG environment.

After adjusting for stellar mass, redshift, distance bin, and available group-scale controls, the passive-status model gives a  $\text{CG}_4$  odds ratio of 1.27 (95% CI 0.47–3.46;  $p = 0.640$ ).

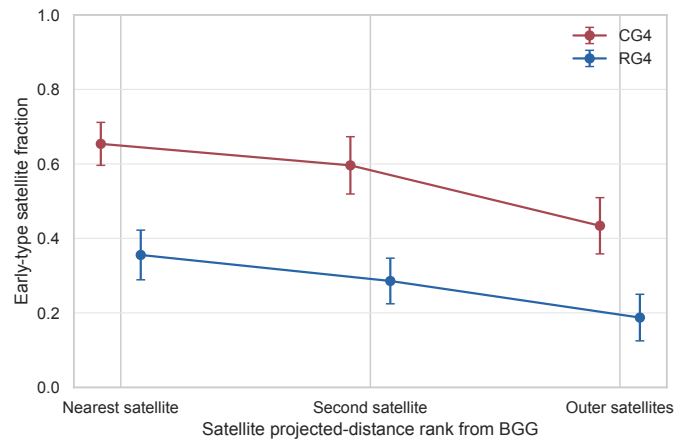
The analogous early-type model gives a  $\text{CG}_4$  odds ratio of 2.57 ( $p = 0.058$ ).

A nearest-neighbour mass-redshift matched check uses 128  $\text{CG}_4$ - $\text{RG}_4$  satellite pairs. The matched passive-fraction difference is 9.4 percentage points, and the matched early-type difference is 19.6 percentage points.

Projected phase-space coordinates should not be read as orbital reconstructions for individual galaxies. In com-



**Fig. 9.** Passive satellite fraction as a function of projected-distance rank from the BGG. Points show  $\text{CG}_4$  and  $\text{RG}_4$  fractions; bars show group-cluster bootstrap 16th–84th percentile intervals.



**Fig. 10.** Early-type satellite fraction as a function of projected-distance rank from the BGG. Because the catalogue separates ellipticals, spirals, and uncertain morphologies but not S0 galaxies, early type is equivalent to elliptical in this diagnostic.

compact groups the member counts are small, velocity dispersions are noisy, and projection mixes recently accreted and long-resident satellites. We therefore treat these bins as an observational diagnostic of where the  $\text{CG}_4$ - $\text{RG}_4$  population contrast appears, rather than as a direct dynamical clock.

### 5.5. Magnitude gaps and fossil-like assembly

We define  $\Delta m_{12} = M_{r,2} - M_{r,1}$  and  $\Delta m_{14} = M_{r,4} - M_{r,1}$ , so that a more dominant BGG has a positive, larger gap.

For  $\Delta m_{12}$ , the  $\text{CG}_4$  and control medians are 1.17 and 1.09 mag, respectively (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.705$ ).

For  $\Delta m_{14}$ , the  $\text{CG}_4$  and control medians are 2.56 and 2.59 mag, respectively (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.705$ ).

The compact-group morphology signal is therefore not accompanied by a significant excess in these simple fossil-like magnitude-gap indicators.

The correlation between  $\Delta m_{12}$  and passive satellite fraction is  $\rho_s = -0.15$  (Holm-corrected  $p < 10^{-6}$ ).

The supporting magnitude-gap distributions are shown in Appendix Figs. C.25 and C.26.

### 5.6. Recently quenched candidates

The catalogues do not contain both  $D_n4000$  and  $H\delta_A$ , so a post-starburst classification is not possible. We therefore perform only a limited  $H\alpha$ -equivalent-width comparison, using the SDSS convention in which negative equivalent width denotes emission. We classify strong  $H\alpha$  emission using  $H\alpha$  EW  $\leq -3$  Å.

The strong-emission fraction is 32.3% in CG<sub>4</sub>, 41.0% in Control<sub>4B</sub>, 45.7% in Control<sub>4C</sub>, 56.9% in RG<sub>4</sub>.

Relative to Control<sub>4B</sub>, the CG<sub>4</sub> strong-emission fraction differs by  $-0.087$  (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.012$ ).

Relative to Control<sub>4C</sub>, the CG<sub>4</sub> strong-emission fraction differs by  $-0.135$  (Holm-corrected  $p = 2.4 \times 10^{-4}$ ).

Relative to RG<sub>4</sub>, the CG<sub>4</sub> strong-emission fraction differs by  $-0.246$  (Holm-corrected  $p = 1.5 \times 10^{-6}$ ).

These limited  $H\alpha$  results indicate that CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies have a lower strong-emission fraction than in each control sample in the current catalogue, but they do not provide a direct post-starburst or recently-quenched classification.

The  $H\alpha$  equivalent-width distributions are shown in Appendix Fig. C.27.

### 5.7. Emission-line and AGN-like populations

The complementary emission-line analysis classifies BPT-star-forming, composite and broad AGN-like populations for galaxies with the required diagnostic line ratios. BPT-unclassified galaxies are excluded from the AGN-like fraction denominator rather than treated as confirmed non-AGN. Among BPT-classified CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies, the AGN-like fraction is 38.0%.

After mass and environment adjustment, the CG<sub>4</sub> AGN-like odds ratio is 1.14 ( $p = 0.451$ ).

Thus, AGN-like activity does not provide a robust independent compact-group discriminator in this analysis.

The AGN-like fractions are shown in Appendix Fig. C.28.

### 5.8. Pairwise tidal index

The pairwise analysis reconstructs projected separations and velocity differences for 6268 galaxies and tests whether adding  $\sum_j M_{\star,j}/R_{ij}^3$  changes the adjusted CG<sub>4</sub> coefficient. The baseline models in this subsection are refit on the pairwise-analysis complete-case sample, so their coefficients need not be numerically identical to the corresponding coefficients in Sect. 5.1. Because  $R_{ij}$  is projected, this term is used as a local projected-density and immediate-neighbour proxy rather than as a direct tidal-history measurement.

For passive status, the baseline CG<sub>4</sub> odds ratio is 1.20 ( $p = 0.227$ ), while the model including the tidal index gives a CG<sub>4</sub> odds ratio of 0.80 ( $p = 0.170$ ). The tidal-index term itself has odds ratio 1.65 ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ).

For elliptical morphology, the baseline CG<sub>4</sub> odds ratio is 1.65 ( $p = 4.1 \times 10^{-4}$ ), whereas the model including the tidal index gives a CG<sub>4</sub> odds ratio of 1.15 ( $p = 0.346$ ). This baseline is the pairwise complete-case refit, not the full adjusted model in Sect. 5.1. The tidal-index term has odds ratio 1.56 ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ). This suggests that the reconstructed local projected-density proxy reduces the unadjusted CG<sub>4</sub> morphology coefficient and reframes it as an immediate-neighbour density signal, although the result remains an exploratory projected-pair diagnostic.

### 5.9. Galaxy sizes at fixed stellar mass

We now test whether CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies differ in size at fixed stellar mass, using the seeing-corrected Simard half-light radii as the primary measure and the Petrosian radii as the model-independent cross-check (Sect. 2.5). The Simard measure resolves 77.4 per cent of the CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies and 72.4 per cent of the pooled control galaxies, while the Petrosian radius is essentially complete in every sample (Appendix Fig. C.18). Because the CG<sub>4</sub>-control difference in Simard completeness exceeds five percentage points, every Simard-based coefficient below carries a differential-completeness caveat and is read together with the Petrosian rerun, which does not share this incompleteness. The descriptive mass-size relations and the per-sample sizes predicted at  $\log(M_{\star}/M_{\odot}) = 10.3$  are shown in Appendix Fig. C.19.

For satellite galaxy size, the CG<sub>4</sub> offset at fixed stellar mass, redshift, and available group-scale covariates is  $-0.003$  dex ( $-0.8$  per cent), with 95% confidence interval  $[-0.033, 0.026]$  and Holm-corrected  $p = 1.000$ , over 3998 satellites in 1527 groups.

The all-galaxy model gives  $-0.003$  dex (95% CI  $[-0.030, 0.023]$ ; Holm-corrected  $p = 1.000$ ), and the BGG-only model gives  $0.007$  dex (Holm-corrected  $p = 1.000$ ).

No coefficient in this primary family remains significant after Holm correction, so the pooled adjusted models do not establish a CG<sub>4</sub> size offset at fixed stellar mass.

The per-control versions of the mass- and redshift-adjusted fit are descriptive and shown in Appendix Fig. C.20; the fitted CG<sub>4</sub> coefficient is  $-0.035$  dex against Control<sub>4B</sub>,  $0.020$  dex against Control<sub>4C</sub>,  $-0.006$  dex against RG<sub>4</sub> (raw p-values with Benjamini-Hochberg control inside this figure family). The sign and significance of the CG<sub>4</sub> coefficient depend on the adopted control, so we do not interpret any single per-control contrast on its own.

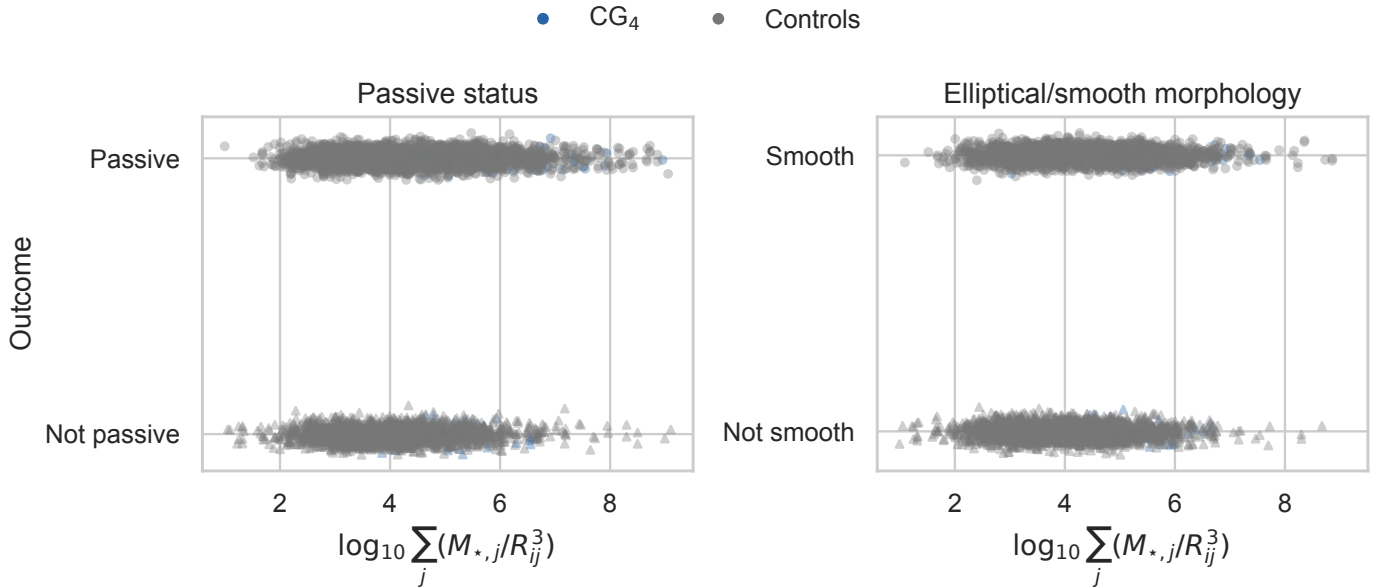
The one-to-one matched comparison re-derives the same 234 propensity pairs as the matched-control analysis, with a separate Holm family for the three size outcomes so that the published matched-outcome family is untouched. On the 163 pairs in which both members have valid Simard sizes, the mean CG<sub>4</sub>-minus-control difference in  $\log_{10} R_{\text{chl},r}$  is  $-0.074$  dex (95% bootstrap interval  $[-0.120, -0.027]$ ; Holm-corrected  $p = 0.006$ ). The corresponding Petrosian difference is  $-0.065$  dex (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.001$ ), and the matched concentration difference is  $0.057$  (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.167$ ).

The matched pairs therefore prefer smaller CG<sub>4</sub> sizes even though the pooled adjusted coefficient is consistent with zero. The matched control set is dominated by the sample whose per-control fit carries the same sign, so we read this as a control-dependent contrast rather than as an independent confirmation of a global offset.

The crowding checks mirror Sect. 5.2: excluding galaxies with a projected neighbour within 55 arcsec leaves a satellite coefficient of  $-0.005$  dex ( $p = 0.791$ ), and adding the close-neighbour flag as a covariate gives  $-0.002$  dex ( $p = 0.875$ ).

The Petrosian rerun, with the field seeing as an additional standardized covariate, gives a satellite coefficient of  $-0.017$  dex (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.350$ ) and an all-galaxy coefficient of  $-0.015$  dex (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.350$ ).

The per-galaxy difference between the two measures,  $d = \log R_{\text{chl},r} - \log R_{50,r}$ , averages  $0.049$  dex, and is larger



**Fig. 11.** Passive status and elliptical/smooth morphology as functions of the reconstructed pairwise tidal index. Colours distinguish CG<sub>4</sub> from control galaxies.

for elliptical/smooth galaxies (0.069 dex) than for spiral/features galaxies (0.038 dex), as expected if the Petrosian aperture preferentially truncates concentrated profiles. Its rank correlation with the nearest-neighbour separation is  $\rho_S = -0.006$  ( $p = 0.687$ ), so residual blending does not drive a strong measure-dependent size systematic (Appendix Fig. C.21).

Adding the pairwise projected tidal index of Sect. 5.8 to the all-galaxy size model changes the CG<sub>4</sub> coefficient from -0.003 dex to 0.022 dex on the pairwise complete-case sample; with a near-null baseline coefficient, the attenuation diagnostic used for morphology is not informative here.

The radial diagnostic is exploratory: mass- and redshift-adjusted satellite size residuals correlate with projected BGG-centric distance with  $\rho_S = 0.17$  ( $p = 0.025$ ) in CG<sub>4</sub> and  $\rho_S = 0.18$  ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ) in the pooled controls (Appendix Fig. C.23). A more negative inner-region residual would be the tidal-truncation expectation; the observed trends are similar in CG<sub>4</sub> and the controls, so the data do not isolate a CG<sub>4</sub>-specific inner-region size suppression.

The concentration index  $C = R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$  provides a model-independent structural proxy: the adjusted satellite coefficient is 0.069 (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.350$ ), so CG<sub>4</sub> membership does not significantly shift the concentration index at fixed mass.

Within morphology classes, the satellite-only fits give 0.033 dex for elliptical/smooth satellites (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.270$ ) and -0.000 dex for spiral/features satellites (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.988$ ), and the CG<sub>4</sub>×morphology interaction is 0.033 dex ( $p = 0.321$ ). These strata are secondary diagnostics; they test whether any size offset is independent information beyond the morphology signal rather than a restatement of it.

### 5.10. Selection diagnostics

The fractions with complete measurements for the major derived quantities are shown in Appendix Fig. C.29.

The colour-matched versus unmatched comparisons quantify shifts in stellar mass, redshift, rank, star-formation class and morphology.

The median nearest-neighbour angular separation is 100.9 arcsec in CG<sub>4</sub> and 209.0 arcsec in the controls; the fractions below the 55-arcsec SDSS fibre-collision scale are 19.4% and 9.3%, respectively.

Under the availability definitions shown in Fig. C.29, no major availability difference meets both criteria of corrected significance and a difference exceeding 10 percentage points.

The group-scale availability row is based on the group covariates available for this catalogue: radius scale, velocity dispersion, group luminosity, and BGG luminosity dominance. A harmonized group-mass estimate is not available in these tables, so models that request it omit that covariate.

The colour-selection mass audit is shown in Appendix Fig. C.30.

## 6. Discussion: drivers of structural evolution in compact groups

### 6.1. Local projected tidal density and morphology signal

The most robust residual difference between CG<sub>4</sub> and the regular-group controls is morphological. CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies are more likely to be classified as elliptical/smooth and less likely to be classified as spiral/features, and this result persists in both the adjusted binomial models and the one-to-one matched comparison. The result hierarchy therefore points to accumulated structural transformation more strongly than to a present-day star-formation offset.

The pairwise tidal-index experiment strengthens this interpretation while also narrowing it. For elliptical/smooth morphology, the pairwise complete-case baseline CG<sub>4</sub> odds ratio is 1.65 ( $p = 4.1 \times 10^{-4}$ ), so it is not expected to match exactly the full adjusted-model odds ratio in Sect. 5.1. After adding the projected pairwise tidal-index proxy, the CG<sub>4</sub>



| Diagnostic                          | Baseline CG <sub>4</sub> signal                        | Survives adjusted/<br>matched analysis?     | Interpretation                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Elliptical/smooth fraction          | Enhanced in CG <sub>4</sub>                            | Yes                                         | Robust accumulated morphology signal.                                                         |
| Spiral/features fraction            | Reduced in CG <sub>4</sub>                             | Yes                                         | Reduced late-type vote-fraction population.                                                   |
| Galaxy Zoo crowding check           | Smooth excess persists after close-neighbour exclusion | Yes, as a limited robustness check          | Morphology result not solely produced by the closest projected pairs.                         |
| Satellite star-forming fraction     | Reduced, especially versus RG <sub>4</sub>             | Weak or borderline                          | Partly explained by mass, rank, environment, or preprocessing.                                |
| Star-forming main-sequence residual | Weak and control-dependent                             | No robust offset                            | No strong instantaneous SFR enhancement or suppression among remaining star-forming galaxies. |
| Satellite colours                   | Colour-slope and residual hints                        | Control-sensitive                           | Exploratory; not a simple uniform reddening or blueing of CG <sub>4</sub> satellites.         |
| AGN-like fraction                   | No robust independent signal                           | No                                          | Not an AGN-driven explanation.                                                                |
| Magnitude gaps                      | No significant excess                                  | No                                          | Not fossil-like under the simple gap diagnostics used here.                                   |
| Pairwise tidal index                | Local projected density proxy is informative           | Reframes much of the morphology coefficient | Local projected density is linked to the morphology signal.                                   |
| Galaxy size at fixed mass           | Hints of smaller CG <sub>4</sub> sizes                 | Matched pairs only                          | Control-dependent; no pooled adjusted offset.                                                 |
| Concentration index                 | $R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$ structural proxy now measured      | No                                          | No independent concentration signal at fixed mass.                                            |

**Table 8.** Result hierarchy. Baseline tests describe where CG<sub>4</sub> differs from the controls; the main interpretation is based on diagnostics that remain after adjusted or matched comparisons.

odds ratio decreases to 1.15 ( $p = 0.346$ ), while the tidal-index term itself has odds ratio 1.56 ( $p < 10^{-6}$ ). This behaviour is expected if compact groups are selecting galaxies in locally dense projected configurations where repeated close companions, rather than the catalogue label alone, are linked to the smooth/early-type-like population.

This proxy uses projected separations, so it may be inflated by line-of-sight alignments and is partly entangled with compact-group selection itself: compact groups are selected to be compact in projection. We therefore read the tidal-index result as a continuous local projected-density or immediate-neighbour proxy, not as a direct time-dependent tidal-field measurement. The Control<sub>4C</sub> comparison makes the test deliberately stringent, because Control<sub>4C</sub> is also selected as a projected compact core around a BGG. The persistence of a CG<sub>4</sub>–Control<sub>4C</sub> morphology contrast in the closest-neighbour exclusion test shows that the CG<sub>4</sub> label is not reduced to the simplest crowding artifact. At the same time, the tidal-index model indicates that a more continuous projected-density proxy absorbs much of the CG<sub>4</sub> coefficient. We therefore interpret the residual CG<sub>4</sub>–Control<sub>4C</sub> contrast as consistent with CG<sub>4</sub> selecting a more extreme part of the local-density distribution, rather than as proof that compact groups define a separate causal channel.

## 6.2. Galaxy sizes and comparison with earlier compact-group size studies

Coenda et al. (2012) compared galaxies in McConnachie et al. compact groups with loose-group and field samples

using SDSS Petrosian half-light radii and found compact-group galaxies to be smaller at fixed luminosity, with the clearest offset for early types relative to the field. Their assessment rested on approximately  $1\sigma$  comparisons of fitted size–luminosity relations, without a formal confidence level on the size difference itself. The present analysis reposes that question with a different control design – the non-split HMCg-based CG<sub>4</sub> sample against three regular-group controls, including the projected-compact-core analogue Control<sub>4C</sub> – and with seeing-corrected model sizes, a Petrosian cross-check, cluster-robust adjusted models, one-to-one matching, crowding tests, and Holm-corrected confidence intervals.

Under this stricter design, the pooled adjusted models do not confirm a compact-group size offset at fixed stellar mass relative to regular groups: the satellite coefficient is  $-0.003$  dex with a Holm-corrected confidence interval consistent with zero. The matched pairs do prefer smaller CG<sub>4</sub> sizes ( $-0.074$  dex), but that contrast is control-dependent. The comparison with Coenda et al. (2012) is therefore nuanced rather than contradictory: their compact-group versus field and loose-group offset can coexist with a null compact-group versus regular-group-core result, because our controls are themselves dense group environments rather than the field.

Three interpretation guardrails apply. A negative  $\Delta$  at fixed mass can reflect genuine tidal truncation or stripping, a higher bulge dominance in the CG<sub>4</sub> population, or residual measurement blending in crowded fields. The morphology-stratified fits address the second possibility, the

Petrosian cross-check and the measure-difference diagnostic address the third, and the crowding exclusions bound the sensitivity of all size coefficients to the closest projected pairs. Any future claim of compact-group size evolution should be read through those three blocks together rather than through a single pooled coefficient.

### 6.3. Smooth morphologies, S0 degeneracy, and transition galaxies

The Galaxy Zoo morphology variables used here separate smooth, featureless systems from galaxies with visible spiral structure or other features. They do not cleanly distinguish classical ellipticals from S0 galaxies, faded disks, or other smooth disk-dominated systems. The enhanced CG<sub>4</sub> elliptical/smooth fraction should therefore be interpreted as a shift toward smooth or early-type-like appearances, not as proof that compact groups specifically build classical elliptical galaxies.

This caveat is important when comparing with the recent S-PLUS structural studies of compact-group galaxies by Montaguth et al. (2023, 2025, 2026a,b). Those studies identify transition galaxies and trends in the  $R_e$ -Sérsic-index and mass-size planes, with especially strong signals in non-isolated compact groups and host structures. Their transition population can plausibly overlap with the smooth class in our catalogue: systems with faded disks, increasing central concentration, or S0-like structure may be counted as smooth here even if they are not classical ellipticals. The two approaches are therefore complementary. Their structural measurements describe the likely physical form of the transformation, while our regular-group controls show that the strongest residual compact-group signal is the accumulated smooth/featured morphology balance. With the Simard structural parameters now attached to this sample, the  $R_e$ -Sérsic- $n$  plane is measured directly for CG<sub>4</sub> and its controls (Appendix Fig. C.22), turning this comparison with the S-PLUS transition-galaxy studies from a qualitative statement into a direct one.

### 6.4. Decoupling between morphology and instantaneous star formation

The star-formation diagnostics do not follow the morphology signal one-to-one. CG<sub>4</sub> satellites have a lower raw star-forming fraction, especially relative to RG<sub>4</sub>, but the adjusted and matched evidence is weaker than for morphology. Among galaxies that remain star-forming, the main-sequence residuals do not show a robust compact-group offset. The colour analysis is also control-sensitive and based on a biased colour-matched subset, while AGN-like fractions, magnitude gaps, and the limited H $\alpha$  diagnostic do not identify a simple alternative driver.

The star-formation non-detections are also limited by the spectroscopy. CG<sub>4</sub> has a higher fraction of galaxies with a nearest projected neighbour below the 55-arcsec SDSS fibre-collision scale than the controls (19.4% versus 9.3%). The control value is pooled over the regular-control comparison; the Control<sub>4C</sub>-only exclusion fraction in Sect. 5.2 is larger (12.8%) because Control<sub>4C</sub> is selected as the compact-core analogue. Spectra are therefore preferentially incomplete in the closest projected pairs, and short-lived interaction-triggered starbursts or post-

starburst phases could be underrepresented. The MPA-JHU aperture corrections use photometric information outside the fibre (Brinchmann et al. 2004; Kauffmann et al. 2003); these corrections may be less secure for interacting or blended compact-group members. We therefore treat the sSFR, SFMS, and H $\alpha$  results as conservative secondary non-detections, not as proof that compact groups have no star-formation effect.

This decoupling suggests that the dominant observable difference is not an instantaneous quenching event caught at the present epoch. A galaxy can lose visible spiral structure, build a smoother disk or bulge-dominated profile, or fade into an S0-like state on timescales that do not require a simultaneously large sSFR residual in the surviving star-forming subset. The present data therefore favour a cumulative morphology or structure signal over a single ongoing star-formation process.

### 6.5. Compact groups as dense cores and preprocessing sites

The comparison samples were designed to ask whether compact groups remain special relative to ordinary group cores, not merely relative to the field. The answer is mixed but physically useful. CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies retain a robust morphology difference, yet much of the interpretation points toward local density, dense cores, and preprocessing rather than toward an isolated compact-group channel. This is consistent with the construction result that many compact groups are embedded in or associated with larger structures, and with the stronger structural signatures reported for non-isolated compact groups in recent S-PLUS work.

The most conservative interpretation is that compact groups identify the high-density, high-interaction tail of group environments. Some systems may be genuinely compact and dynamically evolved, while others may be dense cores or substructures inside larger haloes. In both cases, the relevant physical quantity is likely the accumulated local interaction history. Future simulations and direct structural measurements, including  $R_e$ , Sérsic index, transition-galaxy classifications, and mass-size residuals, are needed to test whether the signal isolated here is unique to compact configurations or is the high-density limit of more general group preprocessing.

## 7. Conclusion

We have tested whether galaxies in CG<sub>4</sub> compact groups remain special after removing split systems and comparing them with three regular-group analogues: RG<sub>4</sub>, Control<sub>4B</sub>, and Control<sub>4C</sub>. The comparison was designed to separate compact configurations from ordinary four-member groups, luminous group cores, and projected compact cores around BGGs.

The main result is morphological. CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies have an enhanced elliptical/smooth Galaxy Zoo fraction and a reduced spiral/features fraction. This signal survives the mass-, redshift-, rank-, and group-adjusted binomial models and is also recovered in the one-to-one matched-control analysis. In the adjusted models, the morphology signal is primarily carried by satellites; BGG morphology is not significantly different after the same adjustment.

The star-formation result is weaker. CG<sub>4</sub> satellites have a lower raw star-forming fraction, especially relative to

RG<sub>4</sub>, but the adjusted and matched evidence is weaker or borderline. Among galaxies that remain star-forming, CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies do not show a robust offset from the fitted star-forming main sequence.

The galaxy-size test adds a structural dimension to this comparison. At fixed stellar mass, redshift, and group-scale covariates, the pooled adjusted models show no significant CG<sub>4</sub> offset in seeing-corrected half-light radius (satellite coefficient -0.003 dex). The one-to-one matched pairs formally prefer smaller CG<sub>4</sub> sizes (-0.074 dex), but the contrast is control-dependent, so we do not claim a robust compact-group size effect.

The secondary diagnostics do not identify a simple alternative driver. The colour results are control-sensitive and based on a biased colour-matched subset. AGN-like fractions and magnitude gaps do not explain the morphology signal, the H $\alpha$  diagnostic is limited by missing age-sensitive spectral indices, and projected phase-space trends do not localize the passive difference uniquely to the nearest satellites. The Galaxy Zoo crowding check shows that the smooth/elliptical excess persists after excluding the closest projected pairs, so the result is not solely a closest-pair classification artifact.

We therefore interpret CG<sub>4</sub> galaxies as a more morphologically evolved population, consistent with accumulated transformation in very dense environments, dense group cores, and/or preprocessing. The pairwise tidal-index experiment shows that adding a local projected-density proxy reduces the compact-group morphology coefficient, so the result should not be read as evidence for a uniquely isolated compact-group quenching mechanism.

This paper now connects the regular-group control framework directly to structural measurements –  $R_e$ , Sérsic index, and mass-size residuals through the Simard catalogue – so the remaining structural future work concerns transition-galaxy classifications and better spectroscopic post-starburst diagnostics. The concentration-index check based on  $R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$  is likewise measured here: the adjusted satellite coefficient is 0.069 (Holm-corrected  $p = 0.350$ ), so this independent structural proxy shows no significant CG<sub>4</sub> offset at fixed mass. Those remaining measurements would test whether the morphology signal isolated here is the same cumulative structural transformation highlighted by recent S-PLUS studies.

## Data availability

The input data are drawn from public SDSS spectroscopic and photometric tables, MPA-JHU value-added measurements, Galaxy Zoo classifications, the Simard et al. (2011) structural catalogue (VizieR J/ApJS/196/11), and the public group and compact-group catalogues cited in Sect. 2. Derived tables and catalogues from this analysis will be made available through an appropriate public repository, and through CDS/VizieR where suitable for catalogue-style products.

## Code availability

The project analysis and paper-generation scripts are publicly available in the GitHub repository [MatthieuTricottet/CG\\_Gals](#). A tagged or archival release corresponding to the final paper version will be made available with the public data products.

## Appendix A: SDSS data query

The SQL query used to retrieve the spectral and photometric quantities from SDSS is listed below.

```

1140 1  SELECT
2      s.specObjID,
3      s.z,
4      p.petroMag_r - p.extinction_r AS
5          r_obs,
6      p.petroMag_u - p.extinction_u AS
7          u_obs,
8      p.petroMag_g - p.extinction_g AS
9          g_obs,
10     p.petroMag_i - p.extinction_i AS
11     i_obs,
12     p.petroMag_z - p.extinction_z AS
13     z_obs,
14     p.objID,
15     g.sfr_tot_p50, g.specsfr_tot_p50, g.
16     lgm_tot_p50,
17     l.h_alpha_eqw, l.h_beta_eqw, l.
18     oiii_5007_eqw, l.nii_6584_eqw,
19     l.h_alpha_flux, l.h_beta_flux, l.
20     oiii_5007_flux, l.nii_6584_flux,
21     z.p_el_debiased AS p_E,
22     z.p_cs_debiased AS p_S
23 FROM SpecObj AS s
24 JOIN PhotoObj AS p ON s.bestObjID = p
25     .objID
26 JOIN galSpecExtra as g ON s.specObjID
27     = g.specObjID
28 JOIN galSpecLine as l ON s.specObjID
29     = l.specObjID
30 JOIN zooSpec AS z ON s.specObjID = z.
31     specObjID
32 WHERE s.z BETWEEN 0.005 AND 0.0452
33 AND (p.petroMag_r - p.extinction_r <=
34     17.77)
35 AND s.class = 'GALAXY'
36 AND g.lgm_tot_p50 > -1000

```

**Listing 1.** Query used for selecting spectral & photometric data from the SDSS



## Appendix B: sSFR classification details

We identify BPT-classifiable galaxies by requiring measured values of both emission-line ratios

$$\log_{10}([\text{N II}]\lambda 6584/\text{H}\alpha) \quad \text{and} \quad \log_{10}([\text{O III}]\lambda 5007/\text{H}\beta).$$

Among these galaxies, we flag broad AGN-like systems if they satisfy either

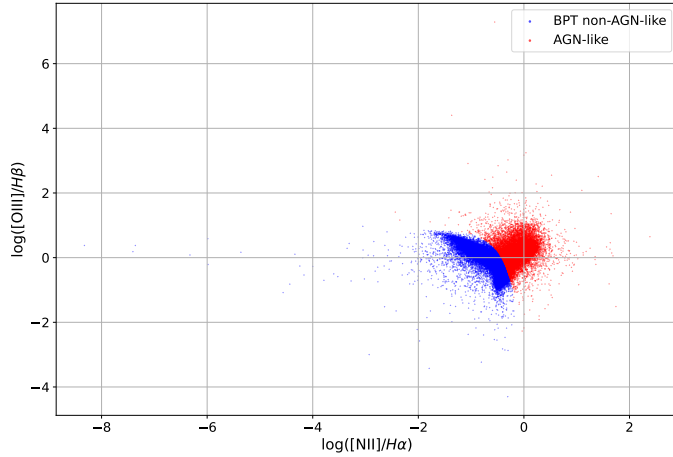
$$\log_{10} \frac{[\text{N II}]}{\text{H}\alpha} > 0,$$

or if they lie above the empirical demarcation of [Kauffmann et al. \(2003\)](#):

$$\log_{10} \frac{[\text{O III}]}{\text{H}\beta} > \frac{0.61}{\log_{10}([\text{N II}]/\text{H}\alpha) - 0.05} + 1.3,$$

in which case they are excluded from the GMM calibration sample. Galaxies with missing diagnostic line ratios are BPT-unclassified, not proven non-AGN. They are retained for the broad sSFR status assignment when valid SDSS stellar mass and sSFR estimates are available, while the emission-line/AGN-like analysis treats BPT-unclassified objects separately. The BPT-classifiable subset is shown in Fig. B.1.

Galaxies with `specsfr_tot_p50` equal to -9999 in the SDSS are classified as quenched (for display purposes, they are assigned the arbitrary low value  $10^{-14.0} \text{ yr}^{-1}$ ). The remaining non-quenched galaxies are divided into passive and star-forming classes with a two-component Gaussian Mixture Model (GMM) in the  $\log M_{\star}$ - $\log \text{sSFR}$  plane ([McLachlan & Peel 2000](#)). The calibration excludes galaxies flagged as AGN-like where the required BPT line ratios are available, while BPT-unclassified galaxies with valid SDSS stellar mass and sSFR estimates can still receive a broad sSFR class. The passive/star-forming boundary is the locus where the two component posterior probabilities are equal. A fixed-threshold robustness check confirms that the qualitative hierarchy is not tied to the exact GMM split.

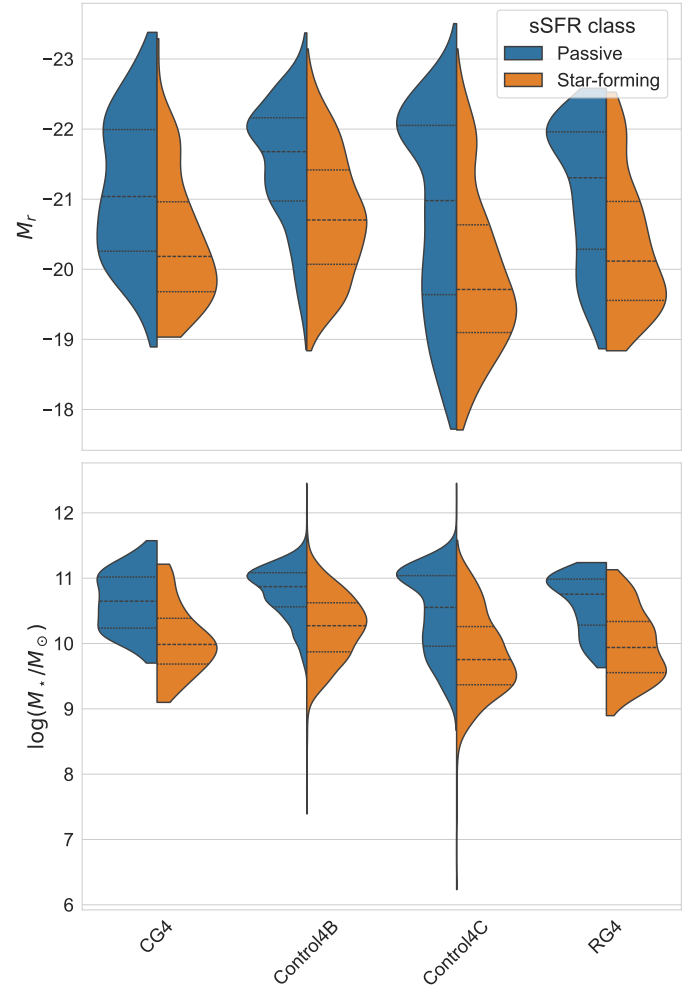


**Fig. B.1.** BPT diagram for galaxies with measured diagnostic line ratios. The AGN-like region is excluded from the sSFR calibration sample; galaxies without the required ratios are BPT-unclassified rather than classified as non-AGN by this diagram.

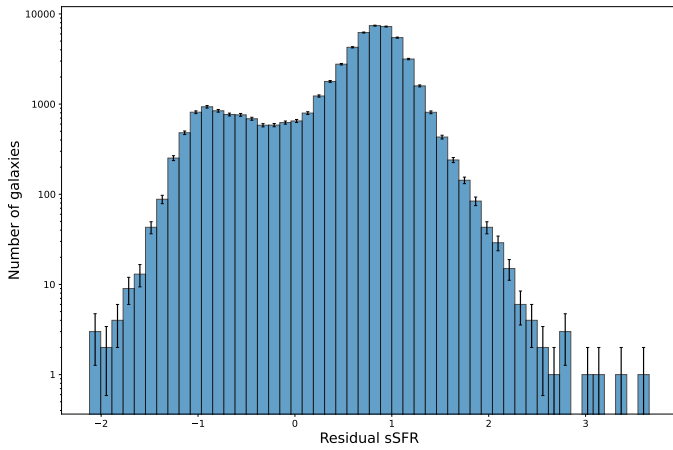
## Appendix C: Supplementary diagnostic figures

This appendix collects the secondary diagnostic figures referenced in the main text.

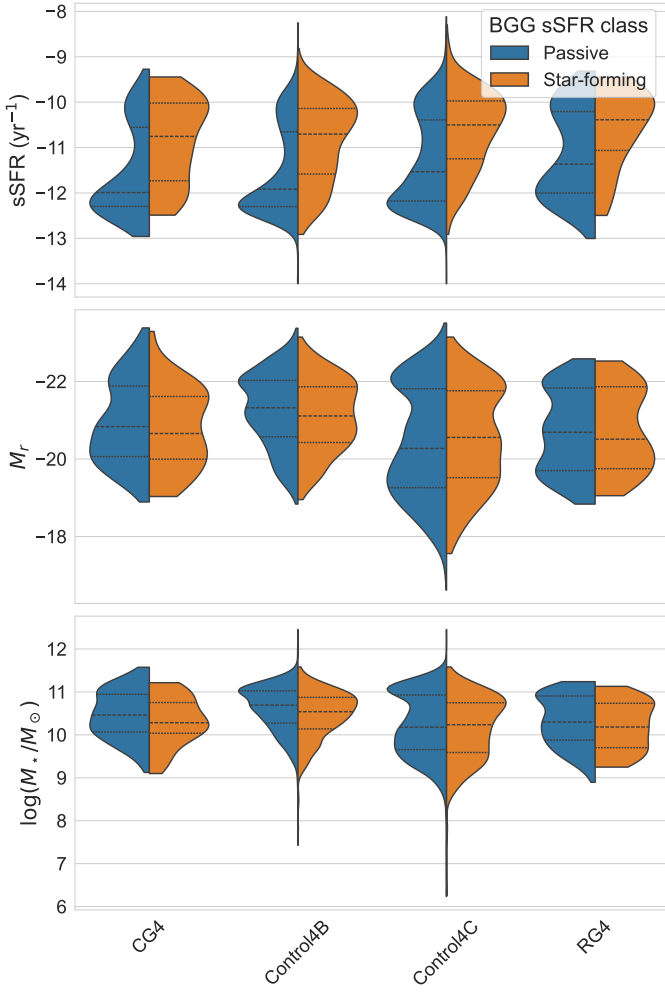
### C.1. *sSFR* and main-sequence diagnostics



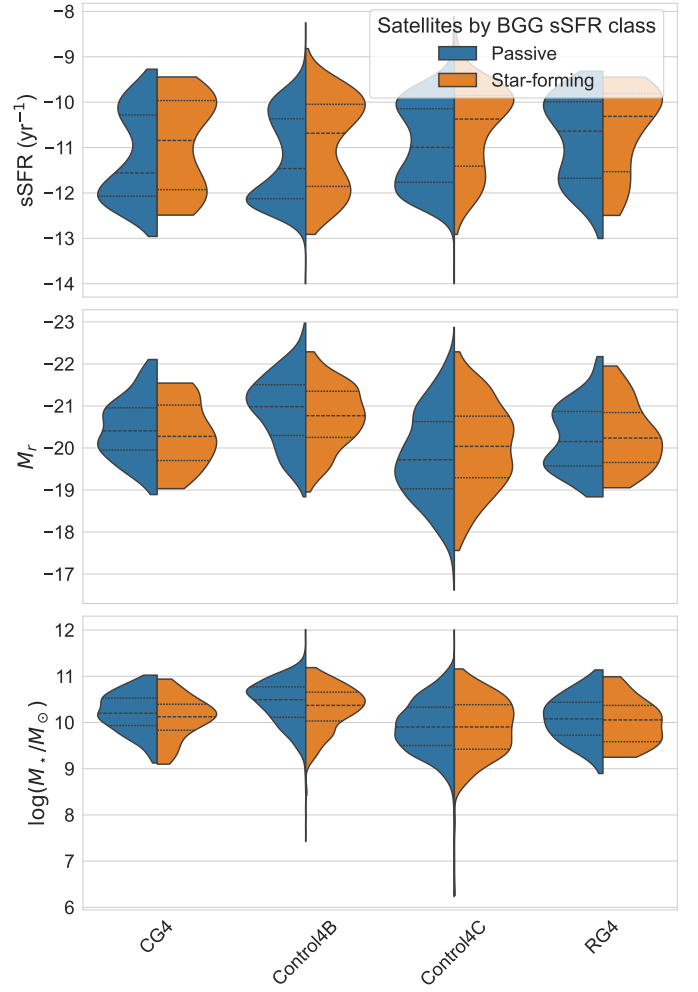
**Fig. C.2.** Distributions of various quantities for galaxies according to their sSFR class.



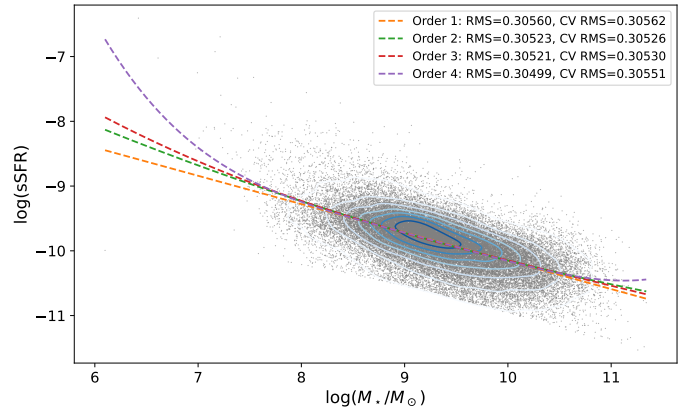
**Fig. C.1.** Distribution of residual sSFR offsets from the adopted star-forming main sequence.



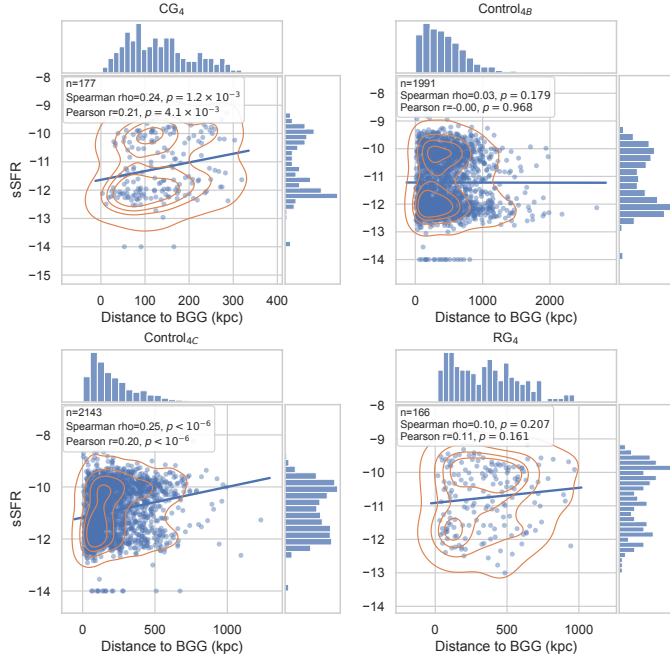
**Fig. C.3.** Distributions of various quantities for galaxies according to the BGG sSFR class, with BGGs included.



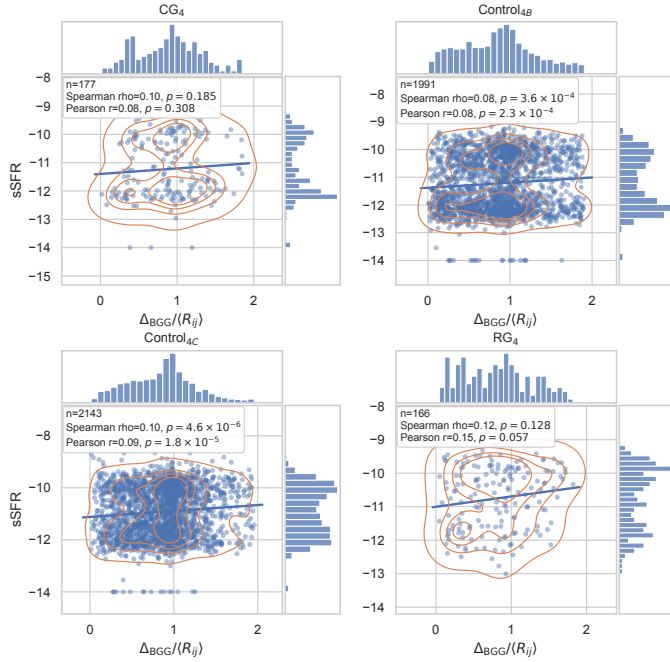
**Fig. C.4.** Distributions of various quantities for satellites according to the BGG sSFR class.



**Fig. C.5.** Polynomial fits of orders 1–4 to the star-forming main sequence. The legend reports residual RMS and five-fold cross-validated RMS scatter in dex; order 2 is adopted because it is the lowest-order model with the smallest cross-validated RMS scatter.



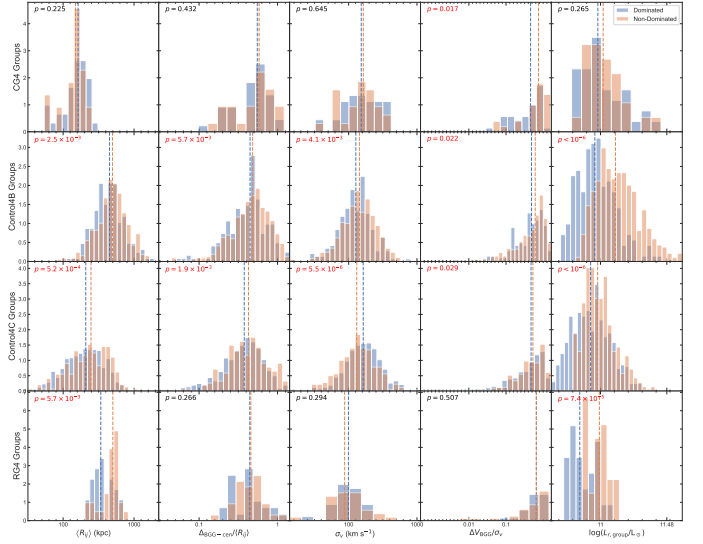
**Fig. C.6.** sSFR as a function of projected distance to the BGG, in kpc, for satellite galaxies in each sample.



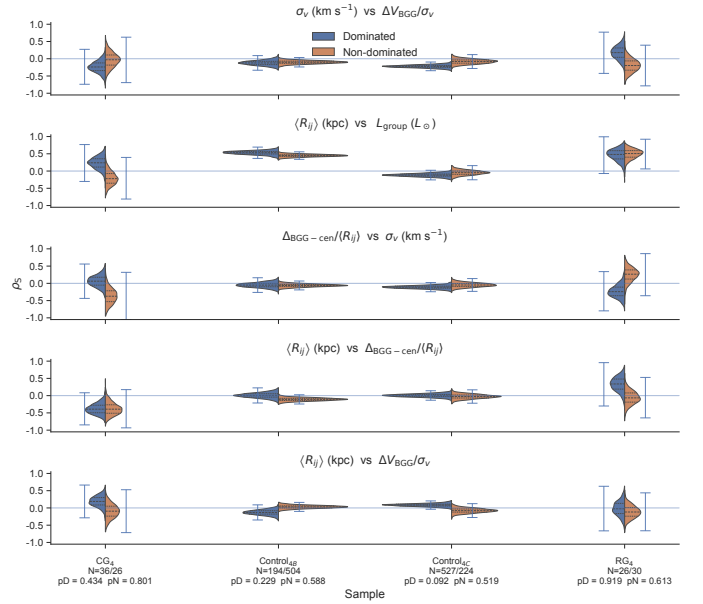
**Fig. C.7.** sSFR as a function of projected distance to the BGG normalized by  $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$  for satellite galaxies in each sample.

## C.2. Group-scale and radial diagnostics

## C.3. Colour diagnostics

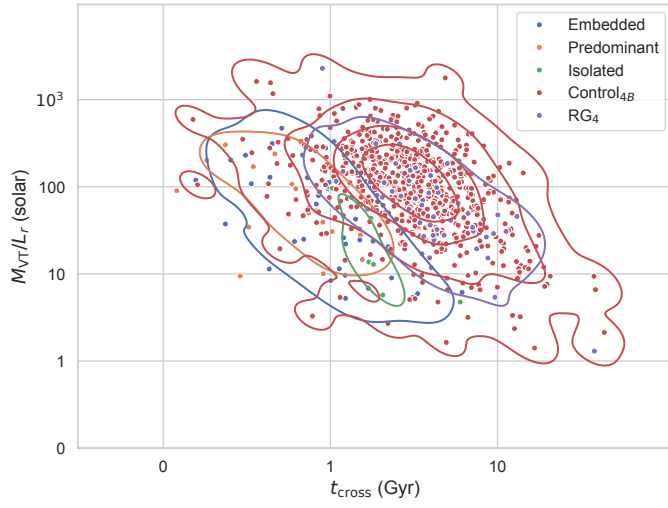


**Fig. C.8.** Distributions of the main group-scale observables in dominated and non-dominated systems.

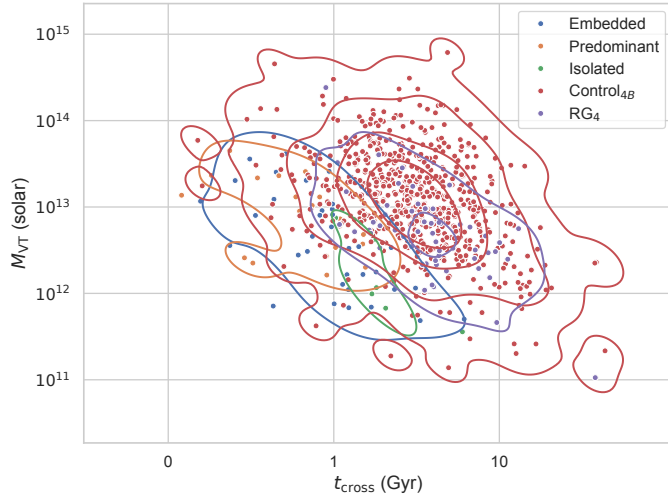


**Fig. C.9.** Bootstrap distributions of the Spearman coefficients for the group-property pairs selected by the XOR domination criterion.

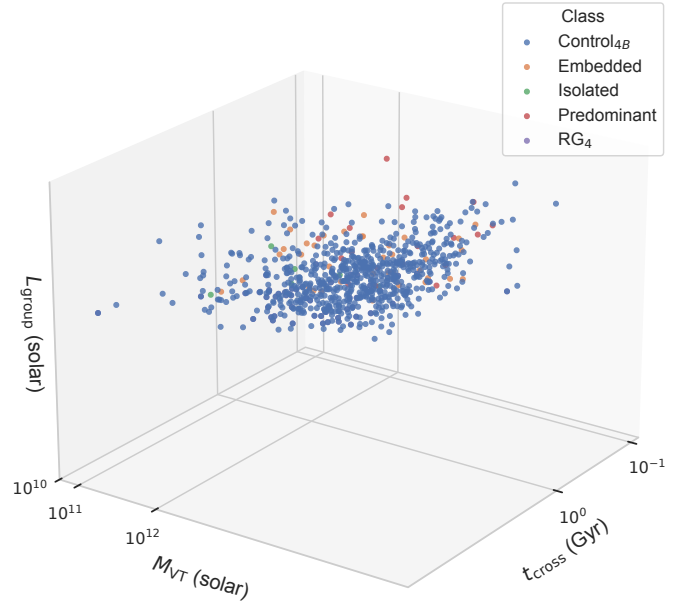




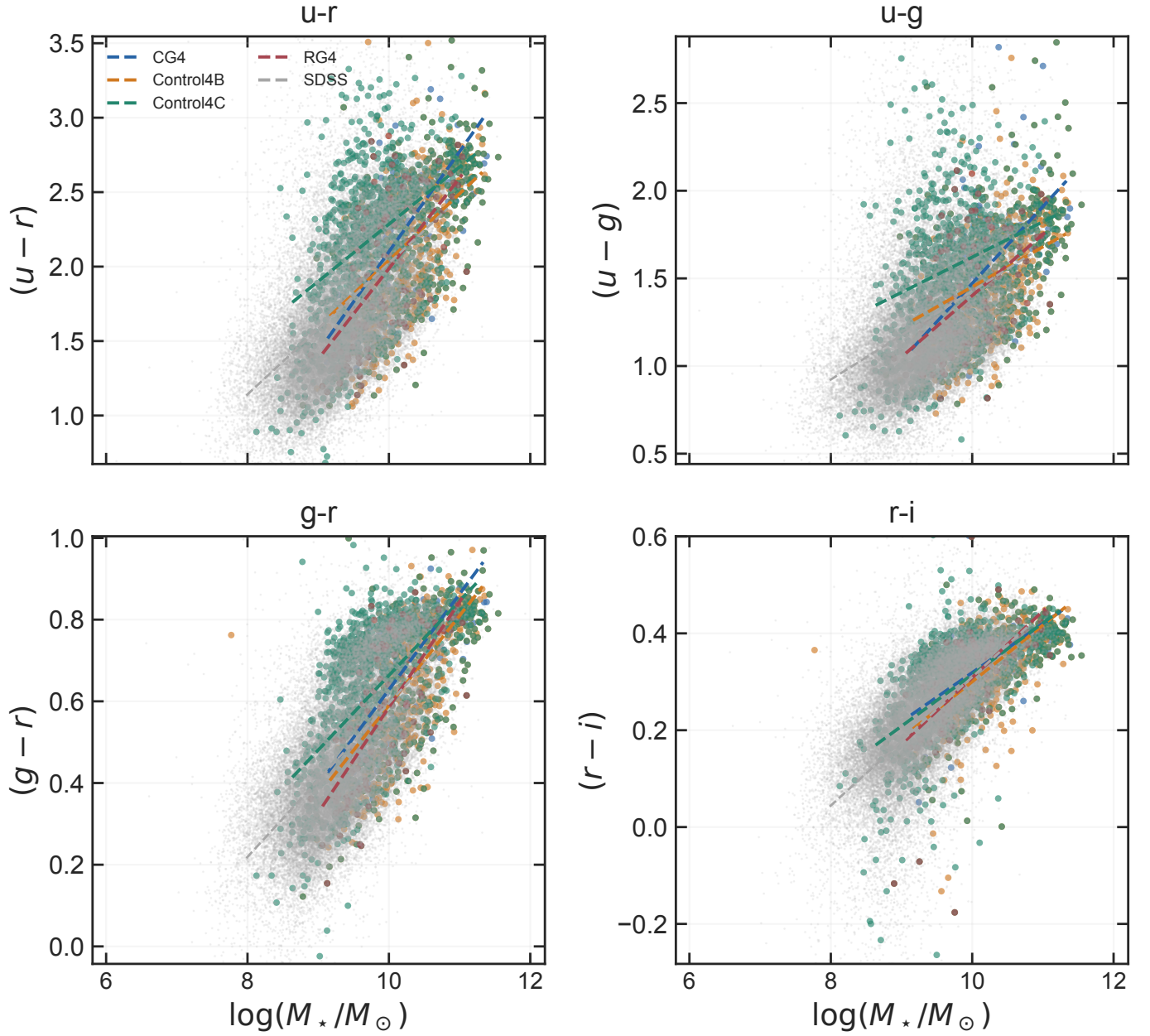
**Fig. C.10.** Crossing time versus virial mass-to-light ratio for the compact groups and their controls.



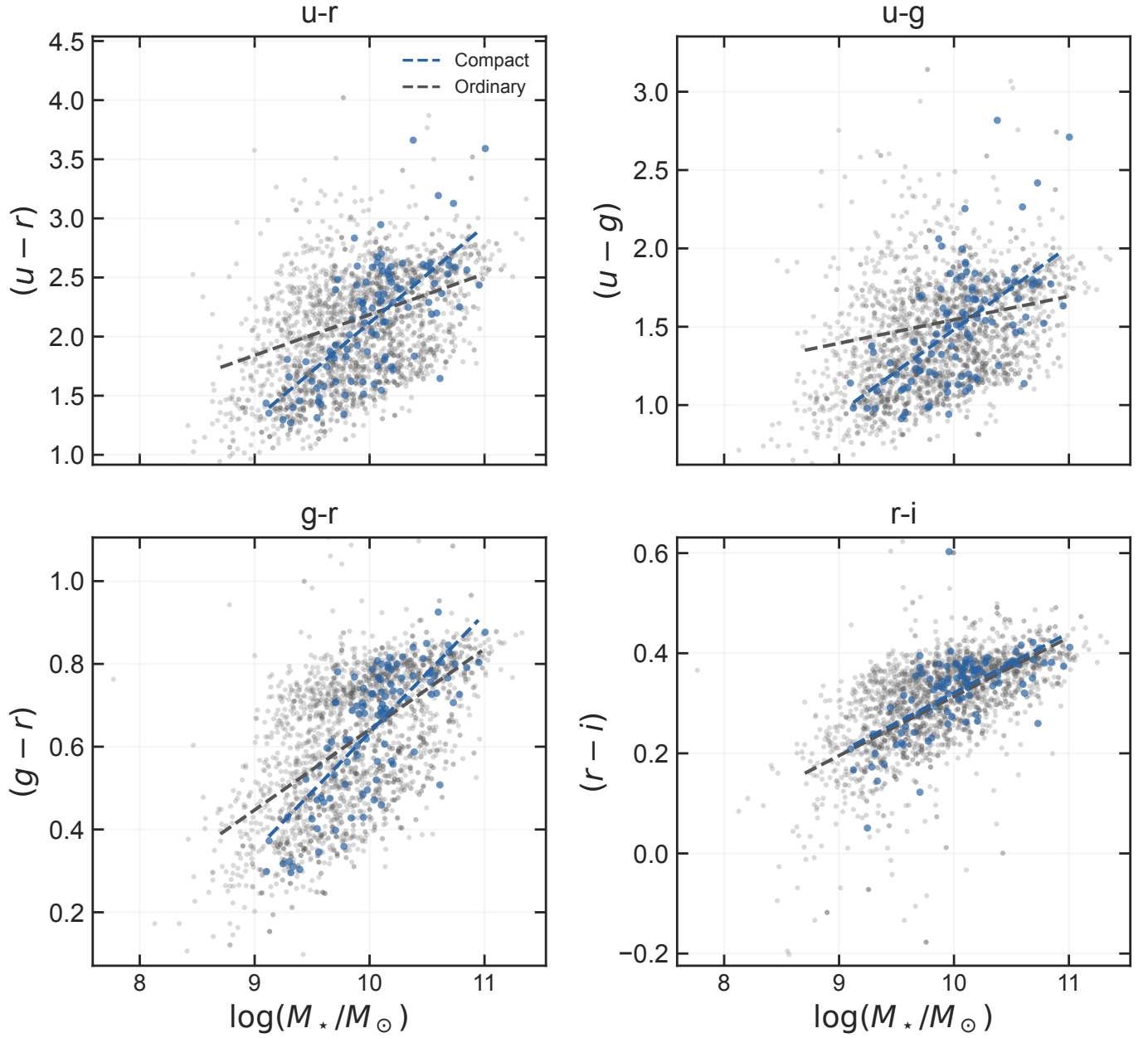
**Fig. C.11.** Crossing time versus virial mass for the compact groups and their controls.



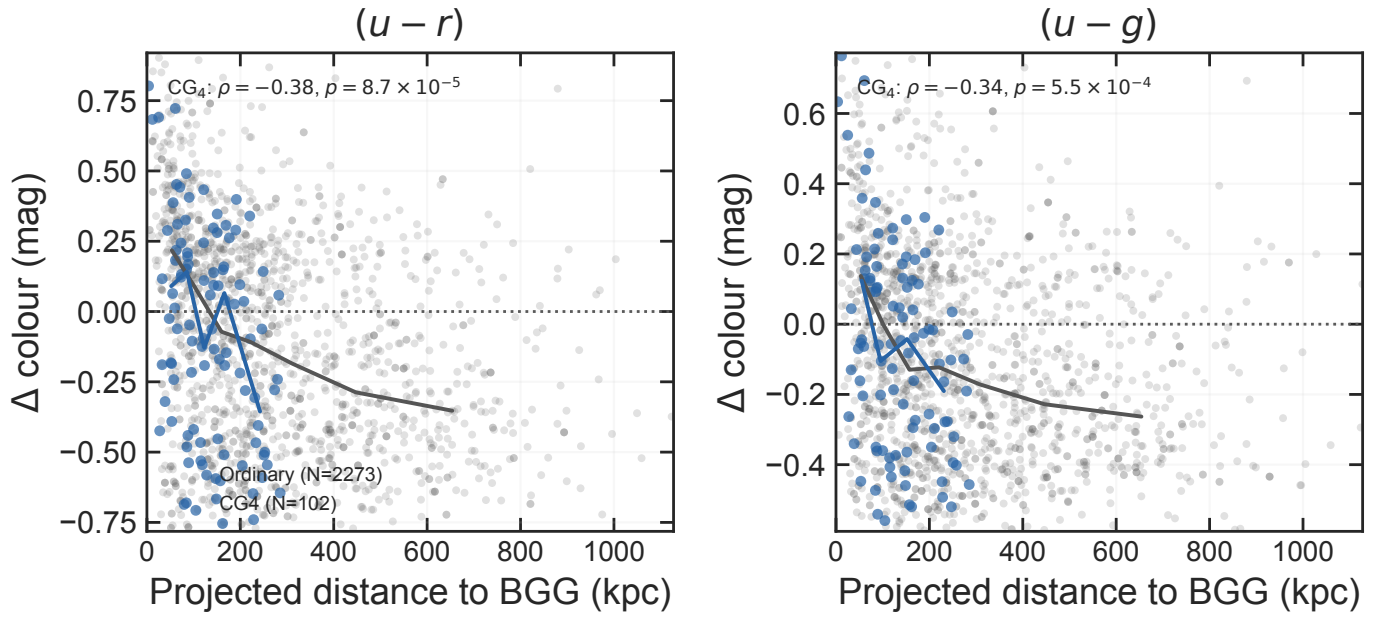
**Fig. C.12.** Three-dimensional view of the crossing time, virial mass, and group luminosity space.



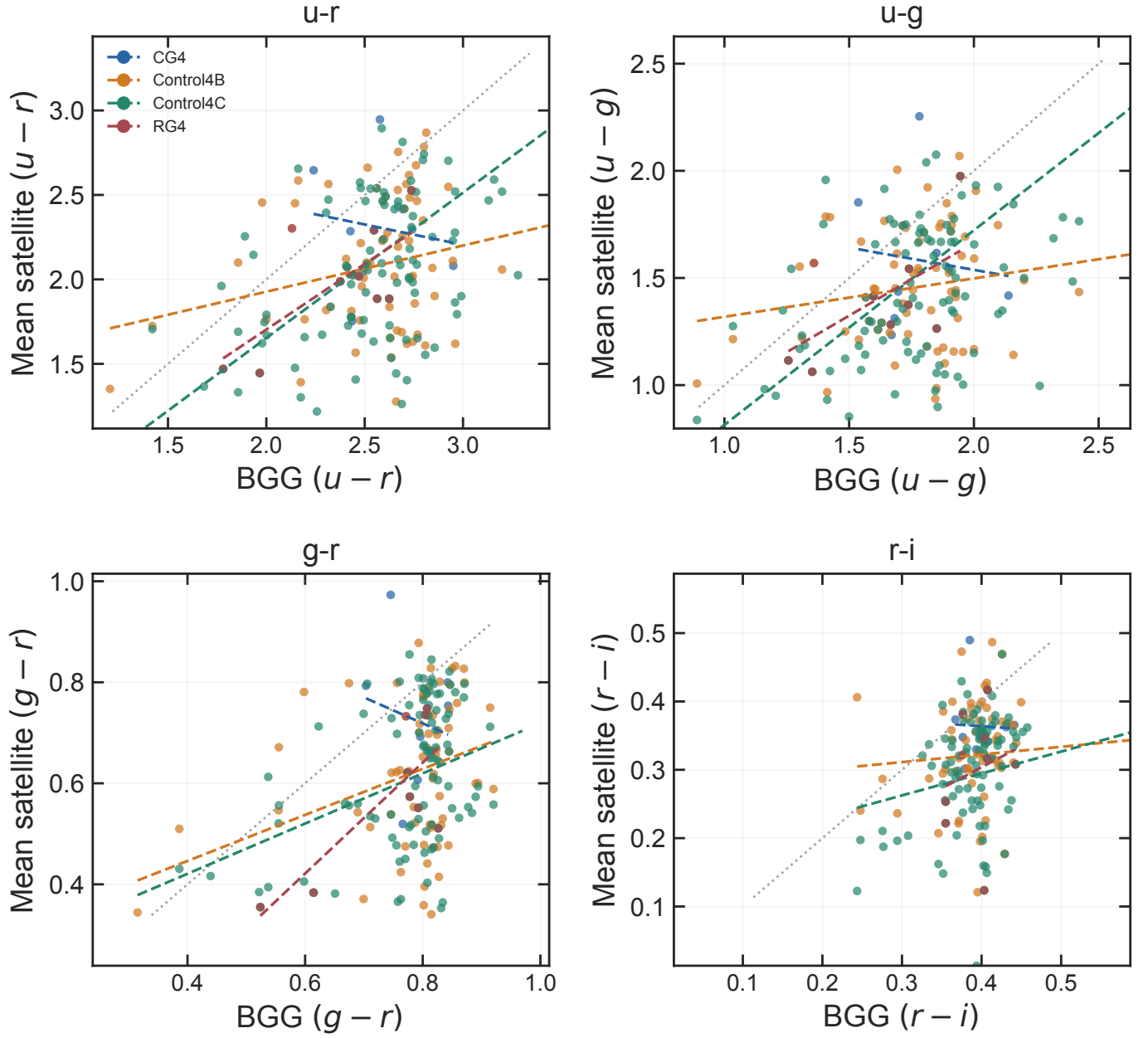
**Fig. C.13.** Optical colour as a function of stellar mass for CG<sub>4</sub>, the three control catalogues, and the matched SDSS reference sample. Dashed lines show the fitted catalogue relations.



**Fig. C.14.** Satellite colour–mass relations in compact and ordinary groups. The fitted lines show both colour offsets at the reference mass and differences in slope.

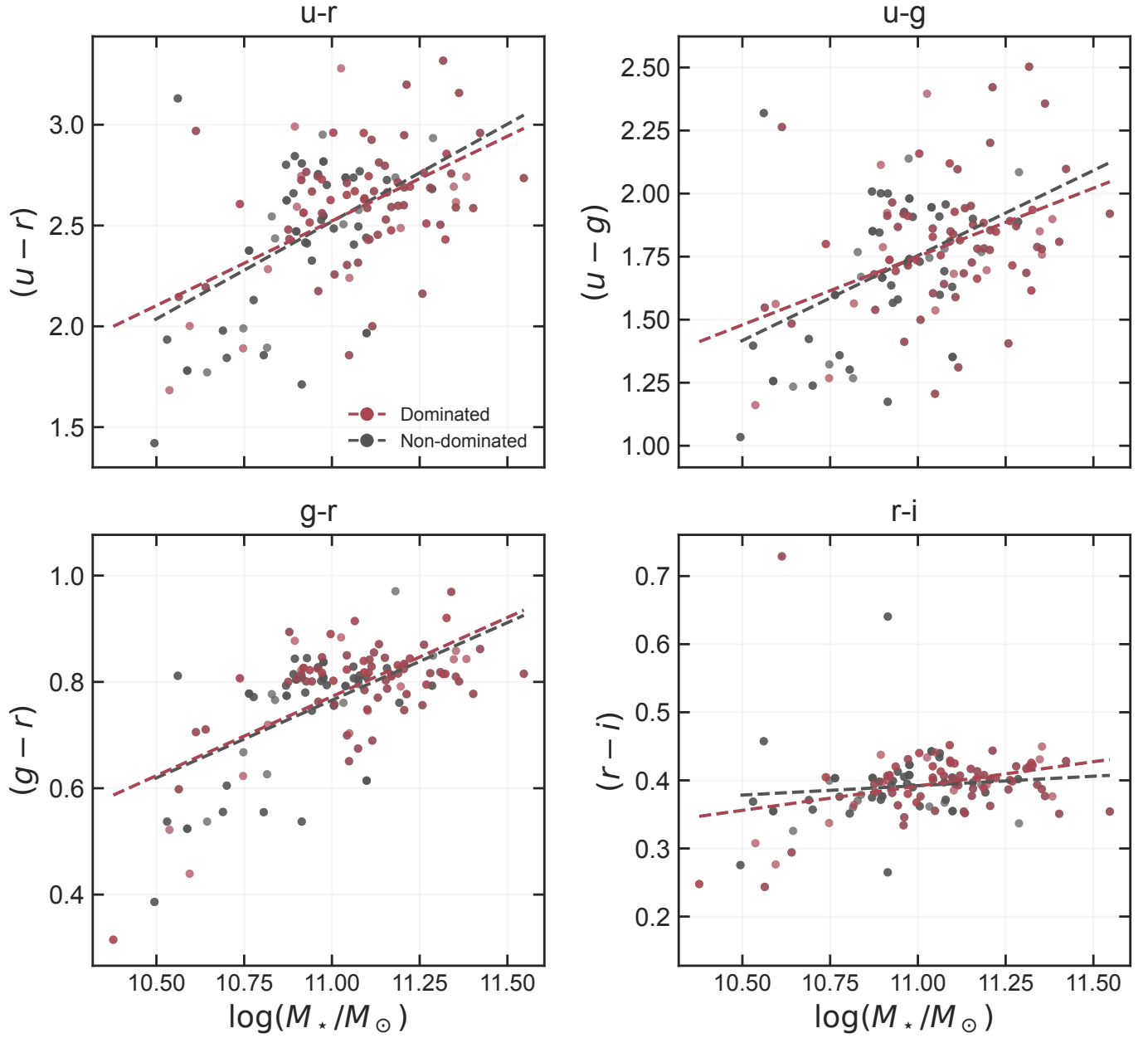


**Fig. C.15.** Mass- and redshift-adjusted satellite  $(u-r)$  and  $(u-g)$  residuals as a function of projected distance to the BGG. Lines connect binned medians for CG<sub>4</sub> and the pooled ordinary-group satellites; extreme plotting tails are omitted for readability, while the reported rank correlations use the full matched sample. More negative residuals are bluer than the ordinary-satellite reference relation.



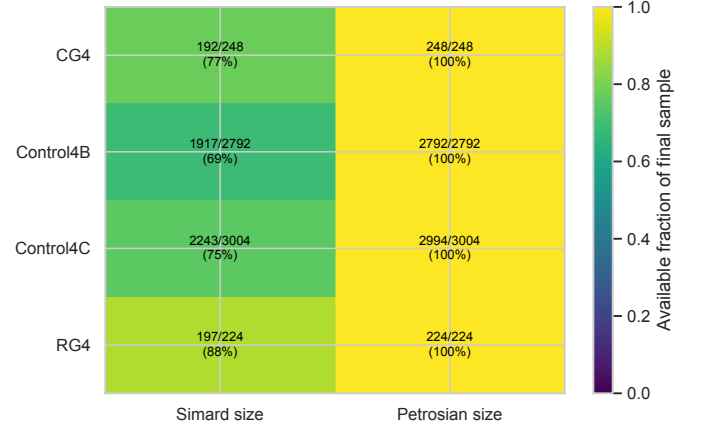
**Fig. C.16.** Mean satellite colour versus BGG colour for groups with matched photometry. The dotted line is the one-to-one relation and dashed lines are catalogue-specific fits.



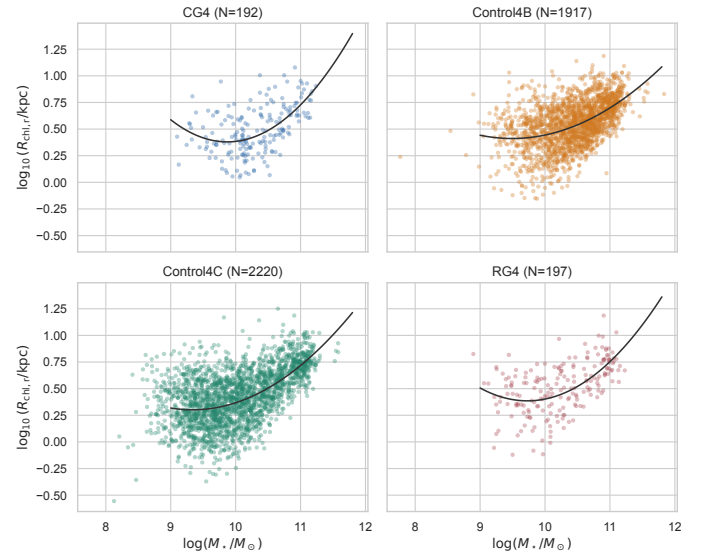


**Fig. C.17.** BGG colour–mass relations split by luminosity domination. Comparing the fitted relations at a common stellar mass separates colour effects from the different mass distributions.

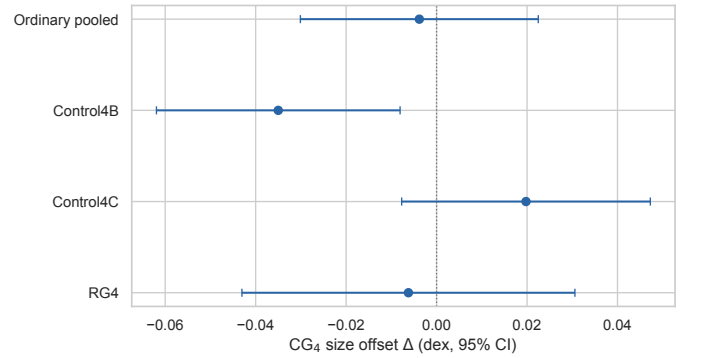
#### C.4. Size diagnostics



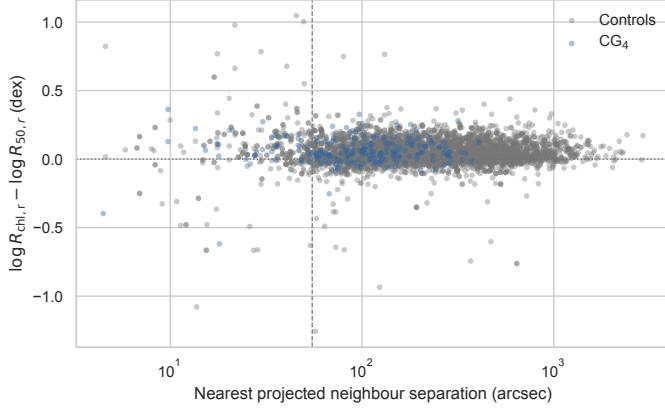
**Fig. C.18.** Availability of the seeing-corrected Simard half-light radius and the Petrosian half-light radius in each sample, after the bridge, quality, and blending cuts of Sect. 2.5.



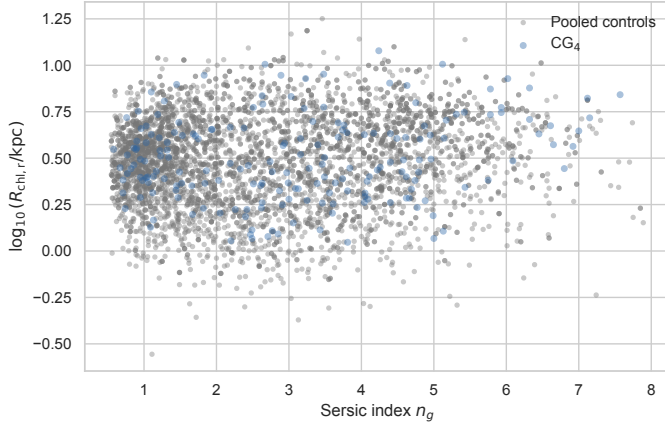
**Fig. C.19.** Seeing-corrected half-light radius versus stellar mass in each sample. Solid curves show the descriptive quadratic fits used to quote a predicted size at the reference stellar mass.



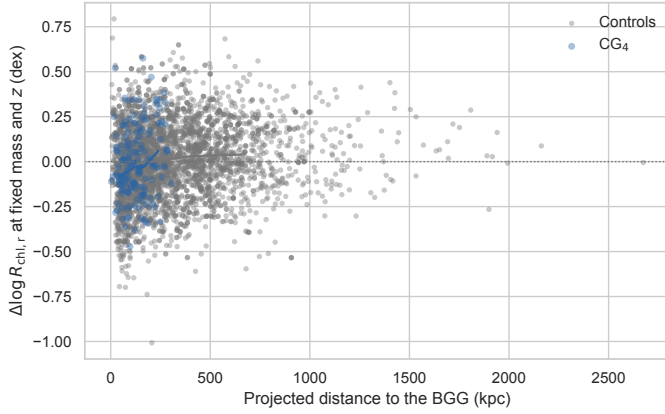
**Fig. C.20.** Mass- and redshift-adjusted  $CG_4$  size coefficients against the pooled controls and against each control catalogue separately. Bars show 95% confidence intervals; negative values mean smaller  $CG_4$  sizes at fixed mass.



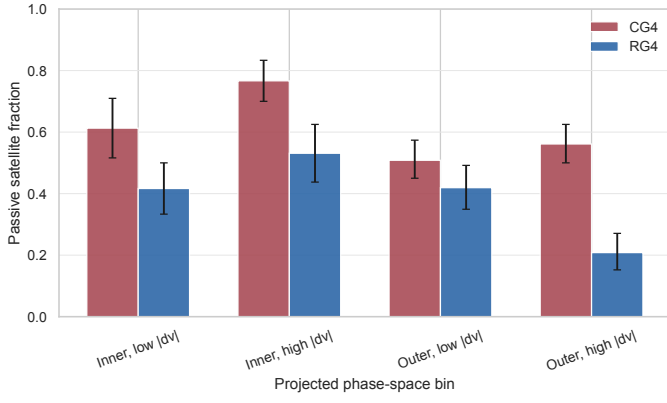
**Fig. C.21.** Per-galaxy difference between the Simard and Petrosian log half-light radii as a function of nearest projected neighbour separation. The dashed line marks the 55-arcsec crowding scale.



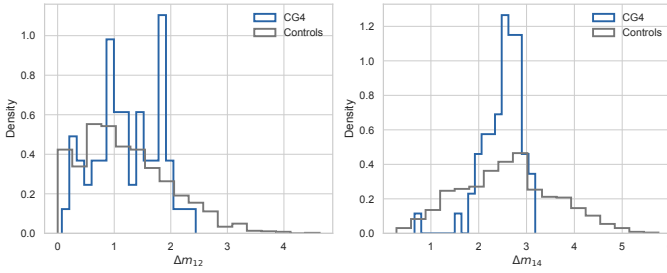
**Fig. C.22.** Half-light radius versus Sérsic index for  $CG_4$  and the pooled controls, the plane used by the S-PLUS transition-galaxy studies.



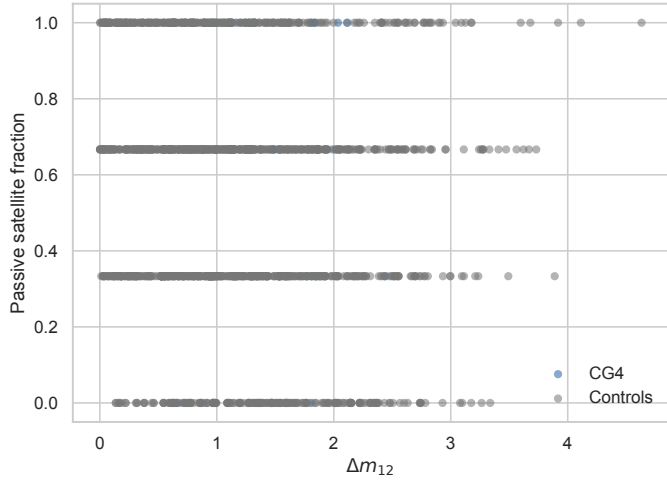
**Fig. C.23.** Mass- and redshift-adjusted satellite size residuals versus projected distance to the BGG. Lines connect binned medians for  $CG_4$  and the pooled controls.



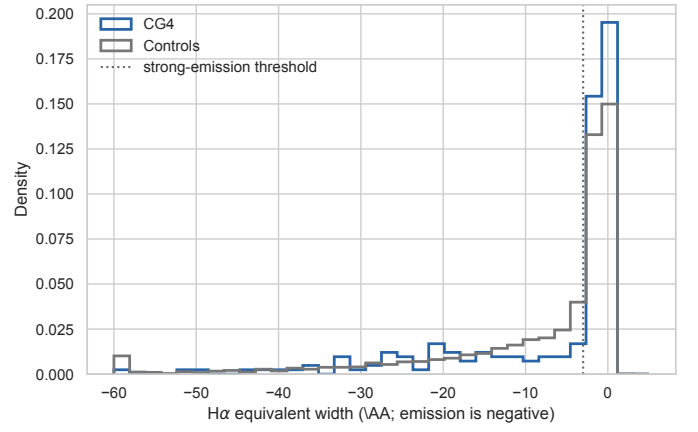
**Fig. C.24.** Passive satellite fraction in coarse projected phase-space bins. Inner and outer refer to projected-distance rank from the BGG; low and high velocity are split at  $|\Delta v_{\text{BGG}}|/\sigma_v = 1$ .



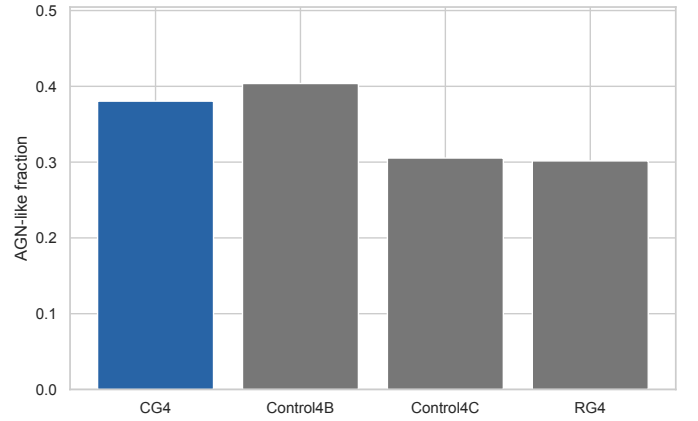
**Fig. C.25.** Distributions of the first-second and first-fourth magnitude gaps in CG4 and the pooled controls.



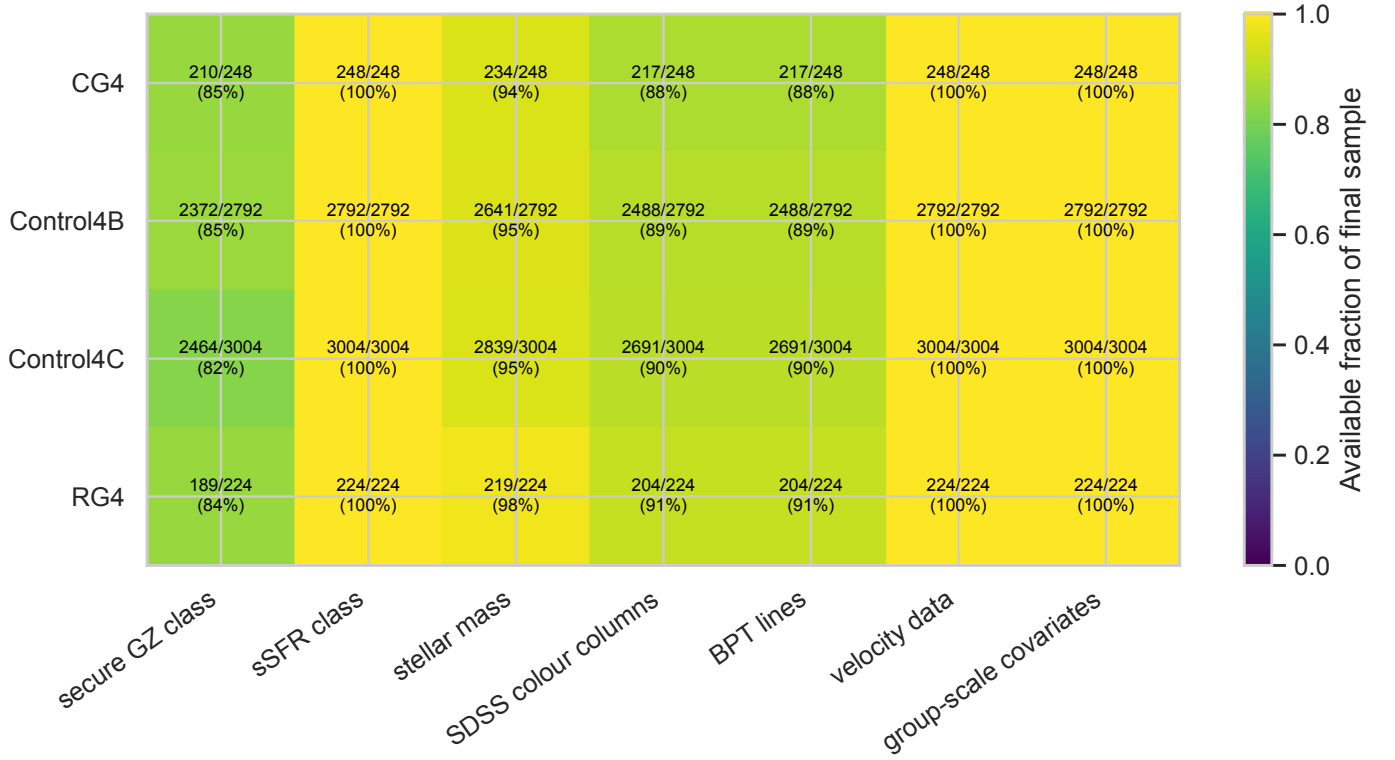
**Fig. C.26.** Passive satellite fraction as a function of the first-second magnitude gap.



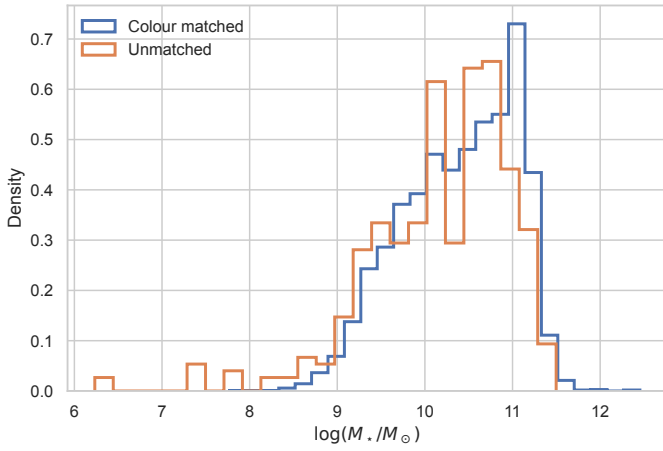
**Fig. C.27.**  $H\alpha$  equivalent-width distributions used for the limited recent-quenching diagnostic.



**Fig. C.28.** AGN-like fractions among galaxies with BPT-classifiable emission-line ratios. BPT-unclassified galaxies are not counted as non-AGN in this diagnostic.



**Fig. C.29.** Availability fractions for the major derived quantities in each sample. The colour row records completeness of the four derived SDSS colour columns in the final catalogue, rather than the stricter colour-analysis matched subset used in Sect. 4.5.



**Fig. C.30.** Stellar-mass distributions of galaxies with and without complete matched colour measurements.



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